

Fighting Shadows

Ryan Nichols

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Fighting Shadows

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Author's Note

This is my account of the life I lived before January 6, the choices I made that day, the years in custody, and the work of coming home.

I have drawn on my recorded recollections, handwritten notes, grievances, letters, medical records, and court documents. The narrative has been edited and arranged from those materials. Passages composed from my recordings and recollections are editorial adaptations, not verbatim transcripts. Direct quotations retain the words of the identified speaker or document.

AI tools were used to help draft and organize those narrative adaptations and to assist with editing and production.

Some dates and sequences are clearer on paper than they are in my memory. Where the records disagree with my recollection, or where a detail remains uncertain, I have kept that distinction. A claim in a filing is a claim. An institutional answer is an answer. Neither becomes the whole story simply because it appears on an official page.

Some people are described without their full names. The events I describe belong to particular times and places; one person's actions do not stand for everyone who worked or lived there. My descriptions of fear, concentration, and survival mode explain how those experiences felt to me.

The account closes with my perspective in September 2026. I am still rebuilding. I can tell the story without pretending that every part of my life has been resolved.

The source notes at the back identify the records and recollections behind the chapters. The grievance reproduced near the opening is a copy of the original, with identifying information masked.

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Prologue. Grievance Resolved

What I Asked For

“I would like to be seen at mental health, please. Thank you.”

Those words are in my handwriting on a grievance dated March 24, 2022. They sit below the signature line, where I had continued writing after the space for my complaint ran out.

The form has a name: Inmate Informal Resolution Complaint Form. It has boxes for the kind of problem a person is reporting, lines for dates, and a place for the Department of Corrections to answer. On my copy, Health Care is checked. There is a received stamp and a handwritten grievance number. The question I was trying to get through that system was simple. I was asking for help.

In the complaint, I said that I had put in a mental-health request after a medical visit on March 21. I wrote that I had not subsequently been seen or asked about my mental-health status. I said I had made multiple requests. Those were the statements I put on the record at the time, while I was still in the D.C. jail.

I did not write them with the distance I have while putting this book together. They were not a later explanation of what prison had done to me. They were a request made from inside the place where I was living.

The complaint runs through the available lines. My final request continues beneath my signature. Someone who has never met me can read it and see what I was asking for.

Please. Thank you. I wanted to be seen.

RECEIVED 4/1/2022 DOC Staff: Print Name _____ RECEIVED 4/1/2022 Sign Name _____ Date _____		PP 4030.1 Attachment C			
DISTRICT OF COLUMBIA DEPARTMENT OF CORRECTIONS INMATE INFORMAL RESOLUTION COMPLAINT FORM		TO BE COMPLETED BY INMATE GRIEVANCE COORDINATOR IGP NUMBER: # <u>20390330-526</u>			
STEP 1: INFORMAL RESOLUTION (To be completed by Inmate) * Inmate has five (5) days after triggering incident to submit request. * Place this form in the housing unit IGP box. The IGP coordinator will respond within seven (7) business days.					
INMATE NAME: <u>Ryan Nichols</u>	DCDC#: _____	UNIT: _____ DATE: <u>3/24/22</u>			
SELECT DEPARTMENT/SERVICES NEEDED: <table border="0" style="width: 100%;"> <tr> <td style="vertical-align: top;"> ☐ Facility Transfer ☐ Fire Safety and Sanitation /Risk Management ☐ Program and Activities ☐ Personal Hygiene ☐ Case Management Services ☒ Health Care ☐ Communications (mail, visits, telephone, legal) </td> <td style="vertical-align: top;"> ☐ Property ☐ Sentence computation, jail credit, over detention ☐ Finance ☐ Rules and Regulations ☐ Staff Treatment ☐ Food Service ☐ Religious Services </td> <td style="vertical-align: top;"> ☐ Facilities Management ☐ Discrimination ☐ Transportation ☐ Safety and Security ☒ Other </td> </tr> </table>			☐ Facility Transfer ☐ Fire Safety and Sanitation /Risk Management ☐ Program and Activities ☐ Personal Hygiene ☐ Case Management Services ☒ Health Care ☐ Communications (mail, visits, telephone, legal)	☐ Property ☐ Sentence computation, jail credit, over detention ☐ Finance ☐ Rules and Regulations ☐ Staff Treatment ☐ Food Service ☐ Religious Services	☐ Facilities Management ☐ Discrimination ☐ Transportation ☐ Safety and Security ☒ Other
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DATE OF INCIDENT: <u>3/21/22</u> TIME OF INCIDENT: <u>All Day</u> OFFENDER: <u>DC DOC</u>					
REASON FOR COMPLAINT: <u>On 3/21/22 after returning from my medical visit, I put in a mental health request. [redacted] witnessed me put this mental health request in. Since then, I have not been seen by medical, or asked about my mental health status. To date, I have put in multiple requests about mental health, and also have IGP's about my mental health due to my conditions of confinement affecting my diagnosis</u>					
INMATE SIGNATURE: _____		DATE: <u>3/24/22</u>			
<u>PTSD. I would like to be seen at mental health, please. Thank you.</u>					
*** FOR DOC COMPLETION *** Provide response to the IGP Coordinator no later than <u>4/5/22</u>					
DOC RESPONSE: <u>Set for mental health appointment on 3/25/2022 and 3/30/2022. Grievance Resolved</u>					
PRINT RESPONDER NAME: _____		RESPONDER SIGNATURE: _____ DATE: <u>4/1/2022</u>			
DEPARTMENT: _____		MANAGER NAME: <u>Corix-19</u> MANAGER SIGNATURE: _____			
INMATE GRIEVANCE COORDINATOR SIGNATURE: _____		DATE: <u>4/11/2022</u>			
Original - IGP Coordinator Copy 1 - Inmate Response Copy 2 - Inmate Witnessed By: [redacted] Revised 3/2019					

Original informal complaint signed March 24, 2022, with the institutional reply dated April 1. The reply records mental-health appointments on March 25 and March 30. Identifying information has been masked. Source: GRIEVANCES.pdf, page 86.

The Answer on the Page

The institution's answer is on the same form. It says that I had mental-health appointments on March 25 and March 30. Then it says, "Grievance Resolved."

That answer belongs in this account. I cannot say what I wrote and leave out what the institution wrote back. The response does not say that nobody saw me. It identifies two appointments. A reader needs that part of the record as much as the request that preceded it.

The disagreement continued. In an appeal dated April 13, I described what I said had happened during those appointments and why I did not consider the matter resolved. The later response again referred to the appointments and said that a follow-up would be arranged to discuss longer-term options. Those later pages form part of the trail I return to in the detention chapters.

For the opening of this book, I want to stay with the difference visible on the first page. I had asked for help. The institution recorded appointments and marked the grievance resolved. I later disputed whether what had happened answered the need I had described.

That is not a medical conclusion supplied by this book. It is the disagreement preserved in the documents. The word resolved tells a reader how the form was closed. My later appeal tells the reader that I did not experience the matter as finished.

Both things remain on paper.

When I speak about confinement, there is anger in some of the telling. There are memories I find difficult to finish. The documents give me another way to explain part of it. They let a reader follow a request, an answer, and what came next. They also keep me from making a broad statement where a specific one will do more work.

I can point to this page. I can say what I asked, show the answer, and explain why I kept asking. That is a different kind of telling from expecting somebody to understand everything because I say the years were hard.

Before There Was a Book

In a recording made after I came home, I said that I had really started this book in the D.C. jail when I began keeping grievances. I did not mean that these forms already contained finished chapters. I meant that I had started preserving what I could say about what was happening to me.

There were requests, replies, dates, and handwritten explanations. Later there were recordings in which I tried to describe things that a form could not hold. In one account of solitary confinement, I reached a point where I wanted to stop talking about it for that evening. In another, I described ordinary fears I had carried home. The pages and the telling did different work.

Some parts of this book rest on records made at the time. Others rest on what I remember. I have tried to keep that difference visible. A memory does not become a court finding because I tell it with conviction. An institutional response does not tell every part of how I experienced the days around it. Each has something to contribute, and each has limits.

I also had a life before any of these forms existed. I grew up in East Texas. I became a Marine. I worked in business and took part in rescue efforts. I became a father. Later, I went to Washington on January 6. My choices there belong in the account alongside the years that followed them.

If I begin and end with the grievance, a reader meets only the man asking for help in a jail. That man is part of me. To understand what I was trying to hold on to, there is more to tell.

The paperwork gives this book one beginning. My life gives it another.

Before the complaint forms, before the public identity and the confinement, there was a boy whose bedroom was a bus.

Part I. Before the Shadows

1. East Texas

The Bus Beside the House

My bedroom was an old school bus with no wheels. We had it sitting on bricks beside the trailer where my parents and my brother lived. We took the seats out, insulated it, put an air conditioner in a window, and sealed it up. We ran electricity to it. By the time we were through, I had a bed, a couch, a television, speakers, a little refrigerator, and chests of drawers.

I loved that bus.

I was fourteen or fifteen, around my freshman and sophomore years of high school, as best I remember. The arrangement is still clear. My parents had the main bedroom in the trailer. My brother had the other room. I had the bus.

That was what we could afford. It was also a place that felt like mine. Those two things belonged to the same memory. I do not have to pretend we had more money than we did, and I do not have to describe a room I loved as though I spent every day wishing I lived somewhere else.

We lived around Fason Street in Karnack, Texas. In my memory, that place is a collection of buildings and a field, a trailer, and the bus beside it. I can still walk through the arrangement when I talk about it. I remember an old snow cone stand across the way. I remember being close to the lake and wanting to go fishing.

We had moved around before that. My dad worked for Walmart, and work took the family to different places. I remember Palestine, Cayuga, and Shreveport among them. When my grandparents' health became a concern, we moved near them in Karnack. I went to school in Waskom from around second grade onward.

The bus gave me some independence while I was still close to my family. It was separate enough that I had to think about things a child in a bedroom down the hall might not think about. I put a lock on the door. I was learning what it meant to have a place of my own before I had much understanding of the responsibilities that would come with a home later.

Someone at the Door

I remember a man trying to get into the bus one night, around the time I was sixteen. I had a shotgun inside. The man left after he realized someone was there.

It scared me. I was a kid in a bus that we had made into a bedroom, and somebody was trying the door.

When I talked about it as an adult, I kept trying to work out what he had expected. Maybe he thought the bus was empty. Maybe he had seen me going in and out. Maybe he thought there was something inside he could take. I offered more than one explanation in the same telling because I did not know what was in his mind. I still do not.

What I can tell is my side of the door. I remember somebody trying to get in, realizing I was there, and leaving. I remember how quickly my own place could stop feeling protected. I do not remember that night as a victory or a story about how tough I was. The fear is part of the memory.

There was trouble around us when I was growing up. Some of my recollections of the neighborhood are rough and incomplete. I have talked about gunshots, a fire, and things I understood only partly as a child. Those memories affected how I saw people. They do not give me a complete account of every event or the right to fill in other people's motives.

That distinction matters to me now. As a boy, I could see something frightening and carry away a conclusion much larger

than what I had actually seen. As an adult, I have done that too. Telling the story carefully means keeping the fear I remember without pretending I knew everything around it.

The bus was still home. A frightening night did not erase the years I enjoyed having my own space. Childhood was not one feeling from beginning to end. There was freedom in that little place. There was also a lock on the door.

The People Who Showed Up

My parents showed up for me.

I caught myself when I told that story too. I started to describe them as always being at our sporting events, then stopped. Work and life sometimes got in the way. Sometimes it was my mother there, sometimes my father. I could not honestly claim both of them were at every single thing. But the ordinary experience of my childhood was looking for support and finding it.

My dad had worked his way up at Walmart. As I remember the family story, the job eventually asked more of him in travel and time away than my parents wanted for us. He left. I understand that decision as him choosing the family, and I have thanked God for it.

My daddy was there. That is what I remember when I think about his work and what he gave us.

My mother made sure we went to church. Sundays were part of the shape of our week, and often Wednesdays and youth group were too. Faith came through people who took me somewhere, sat with me, and kept bringing me back. My grandparents were part of that story before I was old enough to understand how much a family passes down.

My parents also insisted on manners. Yes, sir. No, sir. Yes, ma'am. No, ma'am. Respect was not an idea I first encountered when I joined the military. It was already expected in our house.

The Marine Corps would put different weight behind it, but my mother and father had started the work.

I watched them help people around us even when they did not have much to spare. I remember that alongside the bus and the moves and the things we could not afford. Having limited money did not mean they considered everybody else's needs somebody else's problem.

My second-grade teacher, Mary Crippen, remembered a moment from her classroom when she wrote to the court in April 2024. She said I had pulled another student out of the way of a falling bookshelf. She remembered me as a child who wanted to help and tried to do the right thing.

That was a memory she had carried from long before the Marines, the business, or the storms. When people wrote about my life, some went back that far. They remembered the child who had been in their classroom.

And I loved fishing. I loved Caddo Lake and going down near the Highway 43 bridge to put in. When I speak about East Texas, I can get pulled toward the hard stories because those stories explain something. But the water belongs here too. So do my grandparents, my brother, church, and parents who wanted to be present.

Those are not decorations around the difficult parts. They are the life the difficult parts happened inside.

A Direction I Already Knew

My father had been a Marine. I grew up hearing him talk about it, and from an early age I expected I would serve too. I described it later as something like a calling. It was a direction that was there before I made a formal decision to follow it.

For a while, college seemed to be taking me somewhere else. I went to Howard Payne and played football. I remember thinking

of myself as a college guy. In my mind, that meant the Marine Corps might be something I had once expected to do and would now leave behind.

It did not stay behind.

About a year or a year and a half later, as I remember it, I was in boot camp. The change itself is clear. I had tried one direction, and then I chose the one I had been thinking about since I was young.

I brought more than ambition with me. I brought the way my parents had raised me, the importance they placed on respect, and the experience of people showing up when I needed them. I also brought a young man's confidence that I was ready for more than I understood.

The next part of my life would give that confidence something to answer to.

2. Becoming a Marine

Close the Distance

In boot camp, a drill instructor could call out the name of a phone company and we would know we needed to close the distance to the man in front of us.

“AT&T.”

“Reach out and touch somebody.”

That was one of the sayings I remembered years later. It was familiar language put to a different use. We were on a march or a hike. The point was to catch up, stay together, and respond. It was not a conversation about a telephone.

There were other little responses like that. I remember the word zero being drawn out, and our answer in Lima Company was, “Freeze, recruit, freeze.” I knew other companies had different responses. What stuck with me was ours, the particular way we learned to hear a sound and know what came next.

When I tried to explain this in a recording, I did not deliver a perfect catalog of military sayings. Some came straight back. Others stayed out of reach. I could remember the response better than I could explain every occasion on which we had used it. That is how much repetition had made those words part of me.

They could come back years later in a cell. A phrase from a very different time would still be there. I do not have a dated memory of each time that happened. I remember recognizing how much of the Marine Corps I still carried in the way I heard words and responded to people.

There is a temptation to tell military life through one large dramatic scene. Some of what shaped me happened in these smaller, repeated demands. Pay attention. Stay with the man

ahead of you. Understand what is being asked and do it. A few ordinary words could carry an instruction because we had learned together what they meant.

I was a young man who had grown up saying yes, sir, and no, ma'am. I was now learning what it meant to live inside a different set of expectations, with other people depending on my response.

What Service Gave Me

Joining the Marines was the best thing that could have happened to me. It gave me discipline, training, and a stronger understanding of respect. I learned to defend myself. I learned to function inside something larger than the life I had known at home or in college.

My service record runs from October 18, 2010, to October 17, 2014. I left honorably as a corporal. Those dates give the years their boundaries. What I learned during them stayed with me.

In Okinawa, I took an OC spray course while working with the Auxiliary Security Forces at Camp Kinser. I remember being sprayed as part of that training. I also remember instruction about force and the decisions that go with it. Years later, when I described being sprayed at the Capitol, I went back to that experience to explain why the substance and its effects were familiar to me.

I would later lean heavily on what I believed that training had taught me. At the time, I was a young Marine learning a job and remembering what it felt like to be sprayed.

I also remember being on gate duty around the tenth anniversary of September 11. The gate assignment and the spray training are part of how I remember that period in Okinawa.

Service gave me confidence. I valued being somebody who could respond when something was wrong. That part of me would be useful after I left the military. It would also become something I

had to examine when confidence and urgency ran ahead of what I could actually know.

The Call Home

I was still new in Okinawa when a message came through the Red Cross about my grandfather. He had fallen, and I needed to get home.

That trip eventually brought a new friend into my life. First, it brought news about my grandfather and the need to get back to my family.

I was trying to get home before my grandfather died. I did not make it.

I remember reaching Los Angeles and calling home. That was when I learned he was gone. I had made part of the journey, but the thing I was trying to get there in time for had already happened.

There is no military response that changes that news. Being willing to go, getting on the plane, and making the trip could not put me back inside the time I had lost. My memory of that journey centers on the call at the airport and learning I was too late.

I stayed home for a period that included leave and recruiter assistance. It was long enough to reconnect with life in East Texas and to meet another young Marine who would remain part of my life.

When people hear that I served overseas, they may picture the distance in miles. That call is how I remember the distance. My family was dealing with my grandfather's death at home, and I was still on my way there.

A Friend From Home

I met Alex through recruiter assistance in Longview. We were young Marines back around home. We spent time together, went out, and became friends. I was based in Okinawa, and he would return to his own assignment. We kept in touch after we went our separate ways.

That friendship was not created by January 6. It had years behind it. When I tell the later part, I want that history to remain visible, because a name in a case file can flatten a relationship into the one event for which strangers know it.

Alex also described our friendship in a letter written during the case. He traced it to Marine recruiter duty. That was where the connection began.

Another Marine, Michael Cormier, wrote about knowing me in 2013 at Camp Horno, Camp Pendleton. He remembered arriving at the unit as a new Marine and said I treated him with respect. He also wrote that I would step in when others mistreated him.

Michael remembered being new, having difficulty, and seeing me as somebody willing to intervene.

I am grateful he remembered that. Respect had been expected in my parents' house. In the Marines, it had consequences in the way we treated the person standing beside us. Michael's letter described a time when, from his point of view, I lived up to that expectation.

Something to Do With It

After the Marines, I still wanted work that had a purpose I could recognize. In later conversations with Alex, that was part of what we talked about: civilian life, missing the military, and wanting something useful to do with what we had learned.

Search and rescue gave that desire a place to go. There were people who needed help, other volunteers willing to work, and practical jobs that could be done. I could use my energy for something more concrete than talking about the kind of man I wanted to be.

The military had not made me able to fix every situation. The call about my grandfather belonged to the same years as the training and the confidence. Both stayed with me. I knew what it was to want to get somewhere in time and fail to do it.

When I began going toward disasters, I was bringing all of that with me. I was a former Marine, a son, a husband, and eventually a father trying to make himself useful. Other people brought their own histories and skills. We would need more than one kind of help.

Sometimes the first person who helped was nowhere near the water. It was a voice coming through a phone, telling a team where somebody might be waiting.

3. Running Toward the Missing

The Voice on the Phone

A rescue could start with a voice from somewhere else telling us where to look.

We used Zello to communicate during disaster work. People away from the flooded streets could watch maps, pass information, and help direct teams. People on the ground could report what they found. A phone connected those parts of the work.

I remember how much that mattered. When somebody could tell us there might be a person needing help in a particular neighborhood, we could go check. Someone else could keep working the information while we worked the location. The person talking did not have to be in the boat to be useful to the people who were.

One of the voices I came to know used a handle on those channels. I described him in a later recording as resourceful and confident. He seemed to know how to get information to a team and keep things moving. I trusted that because I had experienced it during rescue work.

There were voices on a phone helping us find places to check, and I relied on them.

That reliance became part of the way I understood a team. Some people could travel. Some could bring equipment. Some could stay in contact and organize information. The job needed more than the person who would eventually appear in a picture.

I was drawn to the part where a request became an action. There was a neighborhood to check or somebody we had been told might need help. We could go find out. The work gave me a place to put the urgency I felt when I knew people were in trouble.

Going to Check

During flood work in coastal North Carolina, we were sent to a neighborhood to go through houses and see whether people needed help. A reporter named Marcus DiPaola was there, along with another reporter I remembered as working for Reuters.

That is the order in which the encounter makes sense to me. We had a task. We went to check the neighborhood. The camera was there because somebody was covering what was happening.

In my recollection, Marcus later filmed the dog rescue people came to know me for. What I remember before the camera was the work of checking the neighborhood.

The less visible part came first: getting to a place and finding out what was there. A report that somebody might need help was a reason to look. It was not the same as already knowing the outcome.

The neighborhood, the house checks, and meeting the reporter stay together in my memory. We were already working when the part other people would see began.

Public attention eventually became part of my life. Before that, there was work happening out of view of the people who would later recognize my name. There were volunteers communicating, supplies being gathered, and teams trying to get to the right place. The camera could show one part of that. It could not contain the whole effort.

What Other People Remembered

Michael Oonk wrote about a trip to Houston after the hurricane and flooding in 2017. He had met me the year before through a group of professionals interested in faith, family, finances, and fitness. In his letter, he remembered me urging the group to go help.

Michael described me buying supplies, a boat, and a trailer, and getting people together to do high-water rescues. He also remembered something more specific. He said he saw me take off my life jacket and give it to an older person we were paddling to safety.

Michael wrote that account in April 2021. He had been beside me in the work, and he remembered a person we had helped.

I appreciate the care in his letter. He spoke well of me, but he also said I was not infallible. I can live with that description. A person can do something useful for somebody in need and still make serious mistakes. The useful act remains part of his life. It does not buy him an exemption from the rest.

There is also a letter from Cajun Navy 2016 dated January 3, 2020. Laurie Bridgers described more than a year of volunteer work, including missing-person searches, water rescue, supplies, and cleanup. She identified work during Barry and Imelda. That letter was written before January 6 became the event through which so many people would view me.

I value it for that reason. It belongs to the time when the work was happening. It describes people who knew me through showing up and taking part.

The list of tasks matters as much as the praise. Water rescue was one part. First aid, getting supplies where they were needed, and clearing debris were parts too. Some jobs were dramatic. Some were ordinary work in a place where ordinary life had been interrupted.

When I look at those letters now, I see a record of people working together. Michael remembered one person needing a life jacket. Laurie remembered work continuing across more than one disaster.

Bringing Alex Along

Years after our time on recruiter assistance, I saw a social-media post from Alex. He was sitting by himself in a restaurant booth in Longview. As I remember it, he had made a joke of the empty seat across from him with a little drawn-in figure.

I went to see him.

The memory has an ordinary shape. We caught up at a restaurant, then went somewhere else for tacos. We talked about civilian life and the Marines. Search and rescue came into the conversation as something useful we could do together.

Alex's later letter also remembered a restaurant conversation and an invitation to help with Hurricane Barry. Our friendship was finding a new purpose outside the military.

He became part of the rescue work. We had known each other as young Marines. Now we had something to do together outside the military. We worked in storms, and we kept that relationship through the disruption of 2020.

I remember Alex's composure in difficult situations, including a frightening moment in a boat when I was glad he was there. I trusted him beside me when things became hard.

That trust mattered later. When I asked him to come to Washington, I was asking a friend with whom I already had a history of showing up. I was not choosing a name from a list of strangers who agreed with me online.

I have said since then that I feel responsible for inviting him into something that caused so much pain. I cannot make every

decision he made my own. I can own that I asked him to go. Before that invitation, though, there was this simpler one: come help with rescue work. It was part of how our friendship had continued.

A Life Around the Work

I was also building a business and raising a family. Rescue work existed alongside those responsibilities. It gave me purpose, but it also took me away from home and from the work that supported home.

People who wrote about me saw those parts together. Michael Cormier remembered the Marine he knew and the civilian who went to help in storms. Donald Spradling knew me through wholesale work and also knew rescue work was part of my life. They were describing one person moving between different responsibilities.

That is the person I want the reader to meet before the court case. There was a family. There was a business. There were people who called because something needed doing. I liked being someone who would answer.

I also know that liking that role does not tell me everything I need to know about a situation. A person can feel called to help and still misunderstand what is happening in front of him. That became a hard part of the story I would have to tell about Washington.

For now, the work gave me a direction. When disaster interrupted somebody else's life, I wanted to be useful. At home, I was trying to build something that would last long enough to support my own.

4. Building Something From Nothing

Twenty-Five Percent

Before I started Wholesale Universe, I worked with another wholesaler. As I remembered the arrangement years later, I would receive twenty-five percent of the sales I brought in.

To the younger version of me, that arrangement was easy to understand. I brought in sales, and a percentage came back to me. I was thinking about what I could produce and what I would make from producing it.

Then the business grew. There were employees and other expenses. The owner told me the arrangement was becoming difficult to afford. In my August 2026 account, I admitted that I had not understood his side of that problem at the time.

I felt as if I was doing more work and being asked to make less money. That was how I saw it. I was focused on the deal I thought we had and the effort I was putting in. I did not yet have the same understanding of the costs that sit around a sale.

We did not work out a new arrangement. We split, and I started my own operation.

The arrangement I liked at the beginning no longer worked the same way as the business changed, and I did not know how to resolve that with the person beside me.

It is easy to tell a business origin as the moment somebody else failed to recognize your value. My own later account was less comfortable than that. I could see that the deal had problems from the beginning. I could see that the other man had costs I

had not understood. I could also remember how strongly I believed I was right.

The Idea I Carried With Me

I called my business Wholesale Universe. I had learned the work through somebody else's operation, and I carried that knowledge with me when I left.

I had taken an idea I learned from him and started doing it myself. I had not invented the business out of thin air. There had been someone before me, an arrangement that taught me, and a split I understood differently once I had more experience.

Starting my own company changed which side of the problem I stood on. I could make decisions about the work, but I also had to live with the responsibilities that came with it. I had been concerned about what happened to my percentage. Now I was the person trying to make an operation work.

That is why I can be grateful for what I learned without pretending the split was easy. I wanted to move forward. I believed I could do it. I also had more to learn than I understood when I made the decision.

I do not need an inflated revenue figure to make that part of my life matter. The business mattered because people worked there, customers depended on the work, and my family had a life connected to it. It was something concrete I had helped build.

When I spoke about the origin years later, I was speaking with the experience of having owned a business myself. I could finally describe both my younger frustration and the limits of my understanding. Neither required me to deny the other.

People Inside the Business

Donald Spradling met me through wholesale work connected to Amazon sellers. He later wrote that the company he worked with taught people how to build Amazon stores, while my company supplied inventory. That was one way people came to know the business: through the products and the work behind somebody else's account.

He joined the sales team in Texas in February 2020, according to his letter. Soon afterward, the pandemic became part of the circumstances in which all of us were trying to work.

Donald described having difficulty finding a place to stay. He wrote that I gave him a place in the warehouse, where his office was, and made sure he had what he needed. He also remembered training, industry knowledge, and mentoring that helped him work toward his own apparel business.

Donald wrote his letter in February 2021 because he wanted people to understand the man he knew. He was speaking from his experience with me.

I value that specificity. It brings the business down to a human scale. There was a man who needed somewhere to stay. There was space available. There was work to learn, and somebody who wanted to learn it. Those things are easier to picture than a claim that a company was successful.

The same impulse that took me toward rescue work was part of how I wanted to treat people at work. I wanted to be useful when I could. Donald remembered me that way. His account does not mean I made every decision well. It means he experienced help from me at a time when he needed it.

Brittney Browning had worked for me since 2017. In her handwritten letter, she remembered what happened at the business during COVID. She wrote that I stopped the regular

operation and paid employees to sew masks and deliver them to hospitals.

She also described seeing me help employees with bills and give away food from my own freezer. Her letter moved between those ordinary needs: food, gas money, a meal, somebody who needed help getting through the week.

Those details belong beside the sales and the inventory. A business was also people showing up to work, carrying whatever was happening at home with them. Brittney wrote about the ways she had seen me respond.

What I Thought Would Be Waiting

By the end of 2020, I had several parts of a life that mattered to me. I had a family. I had the business. I had friends from the Marines and from rescue work. I had people who knew me through things we had done together.

When I later recorded the story of going to Washington, I described a decision made inside that life. I was visiting family near Christmas when I saw a post about January 6. I started thinking about going. I talked about it, put the plan online, and invited Alex.

The business did not disappear from my life when I made that decision. It was part of what I thought I would return to. So were the people at home.

I did not understand the scale of what that trip would set in motion for me. What I knew was that I wanted to go, and that I could arrange to go. The next choice was mine.

Part II. The Road to Washington

5. What I Believed, and Why I Went

A Date on the Calendar

I remember being at my in-laws' place in Oklahoma near Christmas when I saw Donald Trump's post about going to Washington on January 6. The words that stayed with me were, "Be there, will be wild."

The post was published on December 19, 2020. I remember seeing it around the holidays and feeling that I needed to go.

At the time, I believed the election had been stolen. I wanted the allegations examined, and I believed January 6 was a day when something could still change. I expected action from people in Washington, including Mike Pence and members of Congress. I am describing my belief and expectation. They are not findings that election fraud occurred or an explanation of what authority any official actually had.

That distinction is necessary because the belief was powerful enough to move me. I did not treat the post as one more thing to read and forget. I saw a date and a place and began making a decision about being there.

I talked with Bonnie about it. In my recollection, she was cautious. I was the one who wanted to go. I put it online and began hearing from people who were also discussing the trip.

The decision was made inside the life I already had. I was with family. I had a business in Texas. I had a friend I could invite and a vehicle I could take. There was no empty space in my life waiting to be filled by Washington. I made space for it because I thought it mattered.

Later, it would be easy to explain the journey as if everything that followed had already been contained in that post. That was not my experience of seeing it. I knew I wanted to go. I did not know the sequence of choices and events that would follow once I arrived.

Familiar Voices in a Different Conversation

After I said I was going, the phone became part of the preparation. People contacted me. I returned to Zello and entered conversations where some of the voices were familiar from rescue work.

The setting had changed. We were discussing a political gathering, but I recognized people through an earlier kind of work. I had heard them when teams needed information and people needed help. That history affected how I listened.

In my recording, I described getting pulled further into those conversations. I heard plans, expectations, and warnings about what might happen in Washington. I was also carrying my own opinions into them. I was not simply receiving instructions. I was talking, choosing, and making preparations of my own.

Familiar rescue-channel voices were now part of a discussion about going to Washington.

That familiarity mattered to me. During a disaster, I had learned that a person on the phone could help get a team where it needed to go. I carried some of that trust into a situation with a different purpose and different consequences.

I also asked Alex to come. He was a friend from the Marines and from rescue work, somebody I had already traveled and worked with. I wanted him there with me. When I look back at what the trip cost us, I remember that I was the one who extended the invitation.

What I Brought

I expected the possibility of a confrontation with counterprotesters. I brought body armor. I also traveled with firearms and ammunition. In my later account, I said the firearms stayed in the vehicle at the hotel in Virginia when we went into Washington.

Prosecutors later quoted a message in which I anticipated that Washington could become a war zone and that an actual battle might happen. They also reported that on January 5 I called the people in the Capitol our enemies. Those statements belong beside my recollection of what I expected and why I packed the way I did.

I have said I did not know a riot would happen. In the recording, I began to say nobody knew, then corrected myself. I could speak for what I knew. I could not speak for every other person who was going.

There were other people making plans I had never seen, having conversations I had never heard, and arriving with intentions I could not know. Even among people who agreed with me politically, I did not have access to everything they were thinking or doing.

I knew my own preparations. I knew I was bringing protection because I thought trouble with counterprotesters was possible. I knew I wanted to be in Washington on January 6. I knew Alex was coming with me.

Those facts are more useful than trying to make my motives sound perfectly simple. I wanted to protest. I expected to be around a large crowd. I thought there could be a fight with people I regarded as opponents. All of that was part of the man who got into the vehicle.

In later recordings, I was direct about having been ready to fight people I thought were Antifa if a confrontation happened. That

part does not disappear because I also describe myself as having gone to protest. It belongs beside that explanation.

The Road Becomes Real

We drove from Texas to Virginia ahead of January 6. I have given conflicting dates for the journey, but I remember arriving at the hotel and preparing to go into the city.

What had been an online discussion was now a journey. We were away from home, checking into a hotel, and getting ready to go into Washington.

On the evening of January 5, we took a ride into the city and walked around. I remembered seeing the White House and the Washington Monument, and going around places where people had gathered ahead of the next day. I was a visitor trying to take in a city while also looking for the event I had come to join.

In one part of the evening, I remember following a chanting crowd. At first, I thought it was a group opposed to us. Then I decided the people were Proud Boys. That change happened in my own understanding as I moved around and heard more. It is a memory of what I thought I was seeing, not a verified identification of everyone in the group.

I also remember a confrontation near the White House area, people being arrested, and spray in the air. I became angry and argued. I did not arrive at the morning of January 6 having spent the previous night quietly removed from everything happening around me.

The details I have told about that evening are limited by where I stood and what I understood. A crowd can make an explanation feel obvious before it has been checked. I could hear something, recognize a word or a group, and feel that I knew the situation. My own change of mind about the people I was following shows how quickly that could happen.

The Choice I Had Made

By the time we returned to the hotel, I was there. I had chosen the trip, invited a friend, packed for it, driven away from Texas, and entered a city where people were gathering for the next day.

I did not yet know which images of me would be on television. I did not know which words I would spend years being asked to explain. I did not know what being arrested would feel like or how long I would be away from home.

I did know why I believed I had come. I wanted to protest what I thought had happened in the election, and I wanted to be present when people in Washington addressed it. That was the explanation I carried into the morning.

It does not answer every question about my conduct. A reason for going is the beginning of the story of a day. It does not determine what every later act means.

The next morning, I put on the things I had brought and went out with Alex. There would be a crowd to get through before we could even find a place to watch.

6. The Morning and the Walk

Getting Into the Crowd

I put on body armor at the hotel that morning. I also had a crowbar. When I described the day later, I acknowledged carrying it and waving it while trying to hype up the crowd.

The armor and the crowbar were with me before the tunnel. I had brought them into the day.

Alex and I took a ride toward the gathering, then walked when we could not get farther by car. I remember closed roads and people moving toward the same area. The crowd was much larger than I had expected to be standing inside.

I have used very large numbers when trying to describe it. I was not counting people. I was describing the experience of looking around and seeing people everywhere, then trying to work out how we could get close enough to see or hear what we had come for.

We could not get near the front. In my memory, we ended up around the Washington Monument, near a tree and a screen. That is the place from which I remember watching and waiting. It was cold. I had my phone and a GoPro, and I was making recordings.

I was excited to be there. I had made the trip and was standing among people who appeared to share the reason I had come. It felt important to record it and to show other people what I was seeing.

The place where I stood also set limits on what I could know. I was not at every part of the gathering. I could see a screen, hear

what reached us, and watch the people around me. I could not see the whole city or what was already happening farther away.

What I Brought Into the Day

I had also used marijuana and LSD that day. I acknowledged both when I recorded my account of January 6.

That was part of the day I described, alongside the armor, the crowbar, the excitement, and the things I said. I cannot give a precise account of how each affected me.

When I described the day later, I sometimes moved rapidly between memory and explanation. I talked about fear, anger, earlier experiences, substances, and things I had learned afterward. Those are not all the same kind of information. Something I believed years later about why the day unfolded cannot be placed inside the morning as though I already knew it then.

At the gathering, I was recording myself and the crowd. I wanted to capture what was happening. That meant the day was leaving traces beyond my memory even before I reached the Capitol.

I have had years to think about those traces. The words on a recording do not become somebody else's because I dislike how they sound afterward. My later account can explain what I thought I meant. It cannot replace what I actually said.

Starting Toward the Capitol

After the speeches, we did not immediately move at the front of the crowd. I remember waiting and letting people begin to clear out before we started walking toward the Capitol.

The mood around me changed as people talked about Pence and what they believed he would or would not do. I heard the disappointment and anger around me, and I was angry too. I did

not have a verified account of every development inside the government. I had what I was hearing while moving with other people.

On the walk, I made threatening remarks about dragging people through the streets. I have since said I regretted those words. I described them in a later recording as inflammatory things I said while angry, and I said I did not mean to carry them out.

That explanation does not make the words harmless. In the same later account, I recognized that threats can frighten people. I said I had spent time thinking about what my words did to others, and that I wanted the story to include responsibility for them.

So the walk cannot be told only as me following a crowd toward a building. I was contributing to what people heard. I had a camera, a voice, and things to say. Some of those things were things I should not have said.

I also remember difficulty with my phone. Calls or connections were not working the way I expected. In later accounts, I offered explanations for that. What I observed was a problem using the phone. I did not observe proof of somebody deliberately blocking it.

There were sounds ahead that I did not understand. I asked Alex about bangs we heard, and I remember taking his explanation that they were flashbangs. That is how the sound entered my memory. I was not inspecting a device or watching every discharge. I was hearing something, asking someone beside me, and continuing to walk.

What Reached Me First

As we got closer, I remember the smell of spray and people dealing with it. People were wiping their faces and eyes. We asked what had happened and heard that people had been attacked.

That statement did not tell me everything I needed to know. It did not identify every person involved or show me how an encounter had begun. At the time, though, it reached me as an urgent explanation for the distress I could see.

I kept moving closer.

In my recollection, the stairs were crowded, and I climbed a wall to get up. I remember helping a woman and being helped up myself. Alex was there too. We reached the area I recognized as the inauguration platform.

I remember people singing the national anthem and saying the Pledge of Allegiance. Those sounds existed in the same afternoon as the spray and the signs of injury. I was trying to understand one thing while another was happening nearby.

Later, it became possible to watch footage from more than one angle and arrange events on a timeline. I did not have that view as I climbed up. I had the people close to me, what they were saying, what I could smell, and a partial view of the area ahead.

My limited view did not stop me from moving toward what I thought needed my attention. That is one of the facts of my own sequence. I did not stand far back until I had a complete account. I kept going.

At the Opening

Near the tunnel, I remember seeing men coming out bloodied and hearing a woman asking for help. People around us were yelling about Antifa. I accepted that explanation before I knew who was at the front inside.

In my later account, I said I believed I was going toward a confrontation with people who were attacking other people in the crowd. That belief was based on what I had seen at the opening and what I had heard around me. It was not a reliable identification of everybody inside the tunnel.

I could see officers in another position above the area. I used what I thought that meant to explain what I could not see closer to the entrance. Looking back through the account, the assumption is clear: because I could identify police in one place, I told myself the people I could not identify somewhere else must be somebody different.

Then I went in.

I was going toward what I thought was happening before I could see clearly what was happening. Once inside, I was among rows of people between me and the front.

7. The Tunnel and the Cameras

Going In

I went into the tunnel because I believed people were being hurt and I needed to get closer. I have also said I thought I was going in to fight people I believed were Antifa. Both statements are in my later account. Leaving one out would make the decision sound simpler than I described it.

I was several rows back when I first entered. I could not see clearly over the people in front of me. I remember movement, pressure, and trying to understand what was happening ahead. My later estimates of how many people were between me and the front changed even as I spoke. I did not know the exact number.

I thought the people at the front were hurting people from the crowd. Outside, I had seen bloodied people and heard calls for help. Inside, I was still working from that explanation even though I could not see enough to verify it.

Then we were pushed back out. I remember coming down the steps and trying to get out of the way. I was frightened by the pressure and by how quickly the situation had changed. In my telling, the encounter involving Officer Michael Fanone followed that first movement out of the tunnel.

I had entered an active confrontation, had a limited view, and came back out scared.

I had gone toward something believing I understood who needed help and who was causing harm. Inside that crowd, my confidence in the explanation was larger than my ability to see what was happening.

Officer Fanone

I remember Officer Fanone down among the crowd. I remember people attacking him. In my own recording, I acknowledged seeing blows, a man using a stun device, and someone reaching for his equipment. I also said I heard a threat about taking his gun and killing him with it.

Those are not details I can leave out while describing people who tried to stop the attack.

My recollection is that I was among the people telling the crowd to stop and trying to get him back toward the police. I have described Alex and others helping too. That is how I remember my part in it.

In later recordings, I also disputed how Fanone had come out of the tunnel. I spoke with certainty about interpretations I had formed from video. The public record describes him being dragged from the police line and assaulted. In February 2023, the Justice Department reported that Daniel Rodriguez admitted assaulting Fanone with a Taser. Its later sentencing account described another man dragging the officer onto the steps.

My disagreement with parts of the sequence cannot erase that assault. Nor can my account of trying to help establish that I alone prevented a death, or tell the reader what would have happened if I had not been there.

I remember holding onto Alex near the bottom of the steps. In the recording, I started to speak for how frightened both of us were, then corrected myself. I knew how frightened I was. Alex would have to tell his own state of mind.

I also remember another officer passing nearby afterward without being attacked by the people immediately around me. That was one limited moment in one part of the crowd. It did not prove that nobody there wanted to hurt an officer. My own

account of what had just happened to Fanone already showed otherwise.

What remains clear in my telling is the confusion afterward. I had seen an officer being attacked. I remember wanting it stopped. I was standing there with a friend, trying to understand what we had gotten ourselves into, and the day was still going on.

Going Back Toward the Front

I stayed in the area and went back toward the tunnel.

In the next recording, I described hearing someone tell the crowd there had been an agreement that people could stand there peacefully. I wanted to get back up to that position. I also said I wanted to go inside and protest. I had heard that people were already in the building.

Those were things I was being told and things I wanted. Hearing a claim of permission from another person did not establish what officers had agreed to, or that I had permission to enter the building.

The confrontation continued. In my recollection, people argued, spray was used, the crowd pushed, and people began moving together. I remember trying to get close enough to see what was happening at the front and then finding it difficult to move backward once I was there.

I described people screaming and saying they could not breathe. I described a woman in front of me, whom I later identified as Victoria White, and blows and spray that I believed were putting people in danger. I was being sprayed too. I remember pulling my mask up and then having the mask sprayed, so that it was no longer helping me in the way I wanted.

I was afraid somebody would die. I could not know every injury or its cause from where I was standing. The fear was real to me, but it could not tell me what would happen next.

I thought about the OC spray training I had taken in Okinawa. I believed I understood the force being used and what I could do in response. In the recordings, I made legal arguments from that belief. My military recollection is not a court's decision about the legality of my actions at the Capitol.

I reached toward a canister that was moving through the crowd. I wanted it. I took it and sprayed toward the officers.

I believed I was trying to stop people from being hurt. I still took the canister and used it against officers. That was my action.

I remember people climbing over others to get out of the tunnel and being down on my hands and knees. I was trying to find Alex. When I came out, I continued warning people about what I believed officers were doing inside.

The Canister and the Record

The statement of offense I signed describes my participation in pushing against officers with the crowd, followed by my signaling for a canister and directing two streams of spray into the tunnel, hitting multiple officers. It places the pushing at approximately 3:56 and the spraying at approximately 4:02 in the afternoon.

The Justice Department's public summary gives the spraying time as approximately 4:01. The records differ by about a minute. The signed statement supplies my admission of the conduct; neither time estimate changes what I admitted doing.

My recollection of taking and using the canister belongs beside that account. I have described the spraying as lasting only seconds and said I handed the canister back. The length I estimated afterward does not change the direction of the spray or make the people it reached irrelevant.

I have also said I did not strike officers with the crowbar I was carrying. That is a statement about a particular act I say I did not commit. It does not cancel the spray I say I did use.

In the same recording, I defended my decision. I said I thought it was right in that moment, even while acknowledging that I should not have put myself in the situation. I need to be honest about that tension too. My account is not a neat statement that I had already resolved every question about the day in one direction.

I believed people were in danger. I acted on that belief. The officers I sprayed were people affected by my action. What I later experienced in custody would not change what had happened to them.

On November 7, 2023, I pleaded guilty to obstruction of an official proceeding and assaulting, resisting, or impeding certain officers, as the Justice Department reported that day. The plea and return to custody have their own place later in this story. Here, the fact of the plea belongs with the conduct I am describing.

Beyond the Tunnel

The public account of my conduct does not stop with the canister. According to the Justice Department's November 2023 announcement, Alex and I entered the Capitol through a broken window, then stood on a window ledge. I had a crowbar and a bullhorn and urged others to enter the building, described the event as a revolution and as no longer peaceful, and called for people with weapons to get them.

My conduct continued beyond the encounter in the tunnel. I was speaking to the crowd and urging other people forward.

There were cameras other than mine. My recollection of a short action or a narrow intention was not the only account of what I did. A person hearing me from below a window did not have access to every thought I later described. That person heard the words I chose to say out loud.

In the recording about Fanone, I said I regretted making threatening remarks. I recognized that threatening language can scare people and affect how they respond. I said I wanted responsibility for my actions to be part of the story.

That responsibility has to reach the things I said when I was angry, the way I encouraged other people, and the actions I took with them. It cannot be limited to an explanation that I did not expect the whole day to unfold as it did.

I have said I was not the same man after years of thinking about those words. That is something my conduct over time has to bear out. A sentence about having changed cannot do the work by itself.

The cameras preserve a version of me I have had to confront. I can explain the beliefs I brought, the fear I remember, and the help I say I tried to give. I also have to leave room for what other people saw and heard me do.

Leaving

Eventually, Alex and I left the Capitol area and began the walk back. The government's account places our exit from the building at about 4:35 p.m. My next sustained personal memory is of the distance we had to walk before getting a ride, the spray on our clothes, and reaching the hotel.

The day had been recorded from angles I did not yet know existed. I had recorded parts of it myself. I had also spoken and acted in front of other people's cameras.

At the hotel, I would turn on the television and begin seeing the day from somewhere other than the place I had stood. Before long, I would make more recordings of my own.

8. The Night After

Back to the Hotel

Alex and I walked a long way before we got a ride back to the hotel. That is how I remembered leaving when I recorded the account in June 2026. I was wearing steel-toed boots, and the walk felt long. I also remembered seeing National Guard personnel coming in as we were moving away.

I remember continuing to walk, wanting to get back, and finally reaching a ride that could take us to Virginia.

We still had our gear on, and we smelled like pepper spray. When I told the story, I wondered what the driver must have thought of us. I could picture how we might have looked to somebody who had not been there with us.

As I remember it, he drove us to the hotel without saying much. He took us back, and we went inside.

At the hotel, we showered and changed. We put the clothes we had been wearing into the shower to soak and try to get the spray out of them.

That is one of the ordinary actions I remember after a day that had become anything but ordinary. Take the clothes off. Wash. Put on something else. There was no way to finish the day by simply getting clean, but those were the immediate things in front of us.

Seeing It on Television

We turned on the television. The news was bad.

In my later telling, I remembered seeing images of where I had been and hearing words such as terrorism and insurrection. I

began to understand that the public account of the day was very different from the account I had been carrying through it.

I had seen the afternoon from one place at a time. The television was putting images from different places together. I began seeing myself inside a much larger event.

We were getting calls too. I remember becoming afraid that I was in serious trouble. The words I used when I later described that moment were direct: I thought I was in a lot of trouble, and I wanted to leave.

My memory of the evening does not give a precise minute for every call, broadcast, or video I made. I move between them when I retell it. What remains clear is that I was still wound up from the day while the television and the phone were forcing me to look at what other people were seeing.

That did not immediately make me quiet. It did not produce one clean moment in which all my anger disappeared and I understood every consequence. I continued talking, and some of what I said made the record worse.

The Videos I Made

I made videos that I should not have made. I said things that I should not have said. That is how I described it in the June 2026 recording.

The account cannot skip from my fear at the television to my later regret as if nothing happened between them. I was still speaking publicly from the hotel. I was still angry. Other people could hear what I chose to say.

The Justice Department's plea announcement describes a Facebook video I posted from the hotel in which I called for violence and said I would be violent. That was part of the government's account of my conduct after leaving the Capitol.

As I remember it, my Facebook account was shut down after I started making those videos. I had kept posting and talking after the physical confrontation had ended for me.

When I have spoken about those remarks since then, I have described being hyped up by the day. That explains how I remembered feeling. It does not transfer the words to someone else.

In another recording, I talked about having time in a cell to consider what threats do to people. I recognized that a listener cannot simply be expected to know I am angry and dismiss what I say. The person hearing a threat has to decide what it means for them.

That later understanding belongs after the videos, where it actually came. I do not want to write a wiser version of myself into the hotel room and let him take the place of the man who was there. The man there had returned from the Capitol, seen frightening coverage, and still chosen to say more.

Delete It

We left the next morning, as I remember it, and headed back to Texas.

On the trip and afterward, I was worried about the recordings on our phones. In my later account, I said I told Alex to delete what he had. I also said I deleted material from mine.

I was not describing routine housekeeping on a phone. I connected the deletion to fear about what was online and what investigators might be looking for. I saw images of us and believed we were going to be identified.

I have said Alex did not delete his material. I cannot give his entire account of what he retained or why. In my own story, that difference became something I worried about, and later

something I tried to interpret. I had no proof that his choice meant he had a hidden arrangement with anybody.

The action I can own is mine. I deleted material, and I urged my friend to do the same.

That matters in a book built from records. I would later want documents preserved, footage examined in full, and people to distinguish what happened from what somebody claimed happened. My account has to include the time when I reacted to fear by trying to make part of my own record go away.

The trip home did not take us outside what had happened. We could leave Virginia. We could cross back into the life we knew in Texas. The images and statements were already elsewhere.

The Days Before Arrest

Over the following days, I kept seeing people being identified and sought. In my account, I remember telling Alex we should be worried because people who had done less than we had were being looked for. That was how I assessed the situation from what I was seeing online.

The passage of a few days did not reassure me. I continued to think about whether investigators would come for us. There was no clear moment when I returned home and resumed life as if the trip had simply ended.

On January 18, I was in Oklahoma with family when the arrest sequence began.

I knew I had been at the Capitol. I knew there were recordings. I knew I had made public statements after I returned to the hotel.

What I did not know was what it would feel like to look at my phone and see officers at my door. The next part of my life began with that image, while I was somewhere else.

Part III. Detention

9. Arrest and Arrival

The House on My Phone

I was in Oklahoma when the camera at my house in Texas began sending notifications to my phone.

It was January 18, 2021. I had gone with my family to stay with relatives. In the account I recorded years afterward, I remembered waking early, getting up, and then lying down again. A few minutes later, the phone started notifying me. I looked at it and saw officers at my door.

I showed my wife the screen. I remember telling her I was in trouble. The day I had been worrying about had arrived, and I was watching it happen to my house from another state.

That distance is part of the memory. I was not in the doorway with the officers. I did not see everything that happened inside the house. I saw what the camera showed me, and afterward I learned more from other people. When I tell the story quickly, those things can run together. What I remember directly is looking at the phone and realizing that the case had reached my front door.

I thought officers might arrive where we were staying too. I kept expecting them at the gate. In my recollection, they did not come there. There were calls about where I was, and I got on the phone with the FBI.

I had been watching the news and seeing images of myself since January 6. I knew there was an investigation. Seeing my house on the phone made it immediate in a different way. Whatever I had thought might happen was now something I had to respond to.

I could still pick up a phone. I could still get into a vehicle. By the end of that day, those ordinary choices would be gone.

Driving Back

I drove back to Texas and turned myself in.

I remember the drive as taking about four hours. That is my estimate from the recording, not a time taken from a travel log. During the calls, I also cooperated with the request to open the safe at the house. I gave the information they asked for rather than making them break into it.

My recollection of surrender is straightforward: once I knew what was happening, I contacted the FBI and came back. I still felt angry about the way officers had arrived at the house. I thought they could have called me. That was how I experienced it, especially because I was not there and had people at home to worry about.

Surrendering did not mean that I understood what would happen next. I had not been through this kind of federal case. I knew I was in trouble, but knowing that was different from understanding how the process would take over my life.

There were people to contact and immediate decisions to make. Then there was intake. I went from being in a vehicle, moving toward a place, to being put somewhere I could not leave.

In my later telling, I could describe the phone, the drive, and the cell. I could also see how much of the life afterward I had not imagined. At the time, I was dealing with what was directly in front of me. I did not know the sequence of jails and transfers that would follow.

The next place I remember clearly was a small intake cell.

The First Cell

Intake happened during COVID. I remember small cells without windows and the feeling of being cut off from outside contact.

The separation from my family was the part I found hardest. I had been away from home before. I had been in the Marines and in difficult situations. This was different. I could not decide to call, leave, or find out what was happening to the people I loved. I was waiting inside a room while their lives continued somewhere else.

Within the first couple of days, I wanted to die. That is what I said when I recorded this part of the story. I had not found a way to manage being alone in that cell. It felt unbearable to me.

I remember being asked questions and having a psychological evaluation. I also remember visits from my attorney in those first days. Those contacts belong in the account. I was distressed and asking for help; it would be inaccurate to describe the beginning as though nobody ever spoke to me or evaluated me.

What I could not understand then was how to live through the time between contacts. The person who came to speak with me eventually left. I stayed.

Years later, when I described intake, I compared that first experience with the way I could tolerate being alone by then. I could sleep and pace and sleep again. I did not like it, but I could do it. At the beginning, I did not have that ability.

I have mixed feelings about having learned it. Being able to endure a room by myself helped me get through custody. It also became part of what I had to understand after coming home. I do not want to put that later understanding into the first few days. Then, I was frightened and separated from my family, trying to get through something I did not know how to manage.

I remember those days as the first box. There would be others. The first one was where I began to learn that knowing people were outside trying to help did not make the hours inside pass easily.

Shackles and the Hearing

The first time I wore three-way shackles, there were cameras outside the courthouse.

I was embarrassed. I remember the U.S. Marshals being professional, and I want that included. Their treatment of me was part of the experience, just as the embarrassment was. I do not need to make them cruel to explain how it felt to be in chains in front of a camera.

I saw Alex again after the arrest. We hugged. We had gone to Washington together, and now we were seeing each other in custody.

The hearing was on January 22, 2021, in Tyler, Texas. I have sometimes mixed up the names of the early proceedings. The hearing that stayed with me was the detention hearing, where evidence was presented and the question was whether I would remain in jail.

I had not understood how much evidence they already had. Seeing it presented against me was different from seeing images on television. I was hearing what the government said I had done and facing the possibility that I would remain in jail.

Our families were still trying to understand what we were up against. In my memory, it felt too early for us to have gathered anything that could answer what was being shown. That describes how unprepared I felt. It does not mean there was no evidence against me. My own conduct and recordings were part of the case.

The transcript preserves more than the evidence against me. Pretrial Services recommended release. Bonnie testified about our family and offered herself as someone who could help supervise me. A statement from me was presented too, but my lawyer read it to the court. I was not giving live testimony in that part of the hearing.

There was also a correction concerning the GoPro recordings. The prosecutor explained that only four files had been provided for the hearing because of time constraints. That limitation was not a statement that I had withheld all the other files. It did not withdraw the separate allegations about deleting material. The distinction matters when I look back at what was actually said in court.

Judge K. Nicole Mitchell ordered that I remain detained. The evidence she discussed included my preparations, messages, threats, and conduct. The hearing was not a trial deciding guilt. It was a decision about whether I would stay in custody while the case continued.

Pretrial Services had recommended release, and my family had offered help. The judge reached a different conclusion. I went back to jail. The cameras and the courtroom had been a change of setting, but they had not brought me home.

On the Way to Washington

I remember spending weeks at Grady County in Oklahoma. When I recorded the story, I estimated six or seven weeks and remembered a major ice storm during that period. The exact movement dates still need the transport record. What stayed with me was the cold, the confined spaces, and the difficulty of the conditions.

I remember problems with the food and showers. I also remember how uncertain a transfer made contact with family.

They could be trying to find out where I was while I was waiting to find out where I would go next.

A transfer interrupted whatever small routine I had managed to learn. I would begin to understand one place, then move again. Another intake, another set of people, another period of trying to work out what I could ask for and when.

There was a flight and more than one stop. I have given different estimates of how many men were on the plane, so I cannot responsibly turn that memory into an exact count. I remember being among many other people in restraints, with the Marshals directing the movement. I remember an overnight stay at Northern Neck and going to Washington afterward.

At the D.C. jail, a group of us waited in a small side cell. Officers and inmates came past the window and looked in. I felt displayed. I could see people looking at us; I could not know everything they were thinking.

I asked whether Alex could share a cell with me. The answer I remember was that I would have my own cell. The officer said it as though that should be good news.

It was not good news to me then. I had already learned how badly I could feel alone in a locked room, and I did not want to go back into another one by myself.

Later, I would describe preferring a cell alone to sharing one. At arrival, I wanted the opposite. I wanted someone I knew nearby.

That was how I entered the place that would define the next part of my life: asking for company, being told I would be alone.

10. The D.C. Jail

Five Minutes Outside

Passing a tray could get me out of my cell.

That was one of the ordinary jobs I learned to value at the D.C. jail. An officer needed food passed, water taken around, or a floor mopped. If I could do the work, I might get five or ten minutes outside the door. Those minutes mattered to me.

At first, I had not understood that I might get a chance to do any of it. I was locked in, like the other men, waiting for someone to come to us. Later, I began building relationships with officers. I talked about my children and asked about theirs. Some of them talked back. Over time, I learned whom I could approach.

I did not build those relationships in a day. In the recording, I described the time it took in weeks and months, sometimes moving between different periods of custody as I talked. The detail work and the door I remember later do not all belong to my first morning there.

What connects them is the need to get outside the cell. I was looking for something I could do that would also give me a little movement and contact with people.

I remember mopping while other men were locked down. I remember passing trays and then being allowed to take water around. The work could lead to a few more minutes out. In a place where so much depended on permission, being useful gave me something practical to offer.

It did not give me control of the unit. It gave me a task, and sometimes enough room to do another one afterward.

Breakfast in the Night

Before I was helping with trays, I was waiting for them.

I remember breakfast coming in the middle of the night during Ramadan. In my telling, I put it around two in the morning, sometimes earlier. That was different from the five- or six-o'clock breakfasts I remembered at other jails.

I also remember the call to prayer. The sound and the food schedule became part of how I remembered those early periods at the D.C. jail. They were things I could hear and experience from inside the cell.

I have given March 9, 2021 as my arrival date. The early Ramadan trays belong to a later stretch, although I have sometimes run those memories together. They were different parts of learning the jail's routine.

During the early period, another man was allowed out to do the work of an orderly. He brought food and coffee and tried to lift people's spirits. I remember that about him. He was in custody too, yet he was moving from door to door and giving people a little contact.

There was a difference between receiving something through the door and having a person there who would speak to you. A cup of coffee came with a chance to exchange a few words. For a man who was spending most of his time alone, that was part of the morning too.

I later became one of the people helping with the work. But first I knew it from the other side of the door, waiting for the person who could come down the run.

Cardboard in the Door

One of the objects I remember best is a piece of cardboard.

By the period I was describing, I had enough of a relationship with some officers that my door was sometimes left partly open. I remember sleeping with cardboard keeping it from closing fully. In the morning, I could open the door myself.

That ability felt important after so much time asking somebody else to open it. The cardboard was ordinary. What it meant to me inside that place was not.

I do not remember it as something everybody could do. I remember it as a small amount of freedom I had managed to obtain through the work and relationships on the unit. The arrangement depended on the people there. It was not the same as being released.

During an inspection, higher-ranking staff found the cardboard. I remember being taken out and another officer speaking up because I helped on the unit. In my account, I did not receive a write-up or get sent into the housing placement I feared.

What stayed with me was being found out, then having someone recognize me as the person who helped. I cannot put an exact date on that inspection.

I had been trying to make the place more bearable. The way I dealt with officers became part of that. It could help me, and it could expose me to trouble. I was learning that the room I had to move in was often decided by someone else's judgment.

When I think about the cardboard now, I think about how much meaning a locked door had acquired. Opening it myself could feel like a major change in my day. I was still in jail. I could still be locked in again. But I remembered having that small choice.

A Call on a Birthday

Other men did not always like the way I dealt with officers.

Some thought I was trying too hard to get along with them. I understood why it could look that way. I was speaking to people who had power over us and trying to get something I needed. The relationships were practical, and I did not always describe them gently when I later talked about the jail.

Then someone would need a tablet to call his child. I remember a man upset on a birthday because he wanted to make that call. If I knew an officer who would help, I could ask.

In the account I recorded, that was the point at which another man could see what the relationship was for. I might get an officer to open a door or let a tablet reach the person who needed it. The same willingness to speak with staff that had drawn criticism could make a call possible.

I do not need to name the child or reconstruct the conversation on the other end. I did not own that family's moment. What I remember is the need in front of me and the effort to find somebody who could respond.

It mattered to me as a father. I was asking officers about their children while missing my own. When another man wanted contact with his family, I understood the importance of it.

I could not make the whole place work differently. Sometimes I could help with one thing: a tablet, water, a tray, a message. That was enough reason to keep trying to know the people who could open the doors.

Learning the People

I remember mistreatment at the D.C. jail. I also remember people who treated me well there.

Those memories belong together. If I make every officer the same, I lose the people whose small decisions helped me endure the place. If I tell only the helpful moments, I lose why those moments mattered so much.

I was learning individual people. Some would listen when I asked for something. Some would let me help. Some would check on me. I came to depend on decisions that might look minor from outside: a little time out, an answer, a task, a chance to speak with somebody.

Depending on those decisions was its own adjustment. Before custody, I had been used to acting when something needed doing. In the jail, I could recognize a need and still have to wait for someone with permission to address it.

The daily routine taught me that repeatedly. A tray came when someone brought it. A door opened when someone opened it. Work outside the cell depended on being allowed to do it. Even when I learned the routine, it remained somebody else's routine to enforce.

I tried to find a place within it. I tried to be useful, to keep talking, and to get through another day. Those things helped. They did not remove the difficulty of returning to the cell when the contact ended.

There were minutes when I was moving and helping. There were far more hours when I was alone with whatever was going through my head. Learning the people was one part of surviving the jail. Learning how to get through those hours was another.

11. Alone

Waiting to Be Fed

A tray running late could change what was happening in my head.

I would be in the cell, waiting. If the food was a few minutes later than I expected, I could start wondering whether anyone was coming. I could not get up and find something to eat. I could not leave the room and ask the person preparing it. I had to wait for somebody to bring it to the door.

When I recorded the story, I described the question that would start: was I going to get fed? I was a grown man, used to making decisions and getting things done, and I could become frightened over a basic part of the day.

That memory helps me explain isolation better than a broad statement about jail. It shows how little it could take to bring my attention back to what I did not control. The delay did not have to last all day. The uncertainty was enough to start me thinking about what might happen.

I did not know every reason a tray might be late. I knew what the waiting felt like. It made me aware of how dependent I was on people outside the cell.

The room was not quiet in the sense of having no sound. I could hear other people, and there were things happening beyond the door. But hearing a place continue around me was different from being able to take part in it. I could know that people were nearby and still feel alone.

I kept waiting for the next thing that would reach me.

The Life Still Going in My Head

My mind did not immediately become as small as the room.

I still thought like a business owner. I thought about my children, about family life, about the things I had been responsible for before I was arrested. In a later recording, I named the ordinary parts of that life: school nights, date nights, family functions, selling something, growing the business, taking a trip, doing a rescue, going fishing.

Those thoughts continued while I was in a cell with none of that available to me.

Before custody, if I was worried about work, there was often something I could do. I could make a call, get in a truck, go to the warehouse, or speak to the person involved. In the cell, the thought could keep moving without my being able to follow it.

There were questions about my case too. There were questions about my decisions. In my account, being alone brought up things I had done and things I should have done differently. I had time to think, but having time did not mean I could put a question away when I wanted.

I described it as having to answer everything in my head. Some things I worked through. Other things became harder. I do not remember a clean dividing line between useful thought and going over the same painful subject again.

I could think about being a father while missing the daily work of being one. I could think about the business while having little control over it. I could picture an ordinary day and then look around at the place where I actually was.

That difference was part of the strain. The life in my head was still full of responsibilities and people. The life available in the room was much narrower.

The Pressure Cooker

An officer described the cell to me as a pressure cooker.

The way I remembered his explanation, closing the door was like putting a lid on a man's thoughts and emotions. Everything stayed inside, with nowhere to go. That description made sense to me.

I had thoughts I did not want to keep hearing. I had anger, fear, and questions about what would happen. Being alone did not make those things orderly. Sometimes it gave them more room to take over.

I read a great deal. I prayed. I tried to find ways to live with the internal conversation because I could not leave the room whenever it became too much. There was no single moment when I mastered it and the difficulty ended.

In my recording, I said I became stronger in some ways and worse in others. I could learn to sit alone and think through something. I could also spend too much time on what was frightening or painful. Both were part of my account.

At times, I believed I had learned to control my thoughts. Then I questioned that description. Was I controlling them, or had I learned to shut things down because they were too much to bear? I said I had not figured that out.

I still want that uncertainty in the story. It is closer to what I told than a lesson about confinement making me strong. I did adapt. I also described damage. One does not erase the other.

The officer's image stayed with me because he was trying to describe the person inside the room. He recognized that something was happening to a man while the door stayed closed.

A Voice in the Room

Sometimes I talked to myself because I wanted to hear a voice.

I have said that plainly in my recordings. I needed something that felt like conversation, even when there was nobody in the cell to answer. It became a habit I would later notice outside custody too.

There were other voices through the vents and doors. I heard men crying and calling for their mothers. I heard threats. Some of the things men said to one another were frightening to hear, particularly when I did not know what might happen if they were together outside their cells.

Hearing a threat was not the same as witnessing someone carry it out. In the cell, though, I still had to decide how to respond to what I heard. I did not know every man, and I could not know which words would remain words.

I also described times when I thought I heard voices or the walls talking. That is how I recalled the experience. I am not giving it a diagnosis here. I was trying to explain what was happening to me and why it frightened me.

Some contact helped. My tray slot faced toward the phones, and I remember being able to look out and see a man using one. He might look over and say hello. That could be enough to give me a moment with another person.

I valued that small opening. I could hear and be heard. For a little while, the voice was coming from someone I could answer.

Talking through the vents became another way of finding people. Those conversations were part of how we got through the hours. They also showed me how much I needed contact, even while I was learning to spend more and more time alone.

What I Learned to Endure

Eventually, I could stay alone for long stretches.

When I spoke about it afterward, I said I could remain in a house or a room for days without talking to anyone. I was not proud of that. I was describing something I had learned to tolerate in conditions where I had little choice.

There were useful things I did with the time. I read books. I began studying law. I thought through parts of my life. I prayed. Those were real activities, and they gave me ways to use hours that otherwise felt difficult to survive.

But I do not want the fact that I found things to do to make the experience sound harmless. In the same accounts, I described wanting to die, becoming afraid of what was happening in my head, and finding ordinary activity difficult afterward.

When I used the word torture, I was describing the harm as I experienced it: mental, spiritual, and personal. That is my description. The grievance forms and court filings preserve the requests I made, the responses that disputed me, and the relief my lawyers sought.

Inside the cell, I was not living a completed legal argument. I was trying to manage the next part of the day. I needed food, sleep, movement, contact, and help with what I was experiencing.

I did ask for mental-health attention. I wrote those requests down. Later, I would dispute whether the contacts I received had answered what I was asking for. The record of that dispute matters because it preserves more than my memory years afterward.

Before the forms became a court filing or a chapter, though, I was still a person trying to get through confinement. I read and prayed and tried to think. I also needed other people.

Some of them reached me through a vent. Some stopped at the door. A few did something small that I would remember long after leaving the jail.

12. The People Who Still Saw Me

Vent Buddies

I remember cell 34 and the men whose voices reached me through the vent.

In my account, two cells downstairs and one upstairs connected with mine. We called each other vent buddies. We talked for hours about our cases, what we had heard, whether we would be released, and what we might do if we got out.

A man could become familiar to me through his voice. We were not sitting at a table together. We were in separate cells, talking through the building.

The subjects were often the same ones already going around in my head. What was happening with the case? How much longer would we be there? What would happen next week? The difference was that another person could answer.

Sometimes we talked about things we could see outside. I remember the Washington Monument and the cemetery behind the jail coming into those conversations. Even looking outward could turn into a question about whether we would ever leave.

We made plans for the next day and the next week. Sometimes we talked about much farther ahead. There were jokes and complaints about officers too. The conversations could be serious, then ordinary, then serious again.

They did not remove the uncertainty. They gave us people to share it with.

I remember how different that was from keeping every thought to myself. I had been trying to make sense of my own situation.

Through the vent, I could hear another man doing the same thing.

Singing Down the Run

At night, we sang.

I remember a man down the run starting “God Bless America” and the national anthem, and other men joining him. In the recording, I associated the anthem with nine o'clock. It became something we did together from separate cells.

One night, I remember an officer telling the man to stop. An argument followed, and officers came back to his door.

From my cell, I could hear the exchange and the movement on the run. I could not see everything happening inside his doorway.

What stayed with me was the fear that a small act of singing could lead to trouble. I remember thinking about the man's size and wondering what that meant for somebody smaller, including me.

The singing mattered because it was shared. We could do something at the same time even while separated. That did not mean all our experiences or opinions were the same. It meant there was a moment when we were making something together.

The confrontation also became part of my growing attention to the grievance process. I was beginning to think about how to record things I believed were wrong. Hearing another man's problem at his door made the question personal: if something happened at mine, what would survive afterward besides the memory?

Another Hour

Recreation time was one of the things men could become most upset about losing.

During the periods I described as twenty-three hours in and one hour out, the one hour had a great deal of importance. I also remembered periods with a longer wait between opportunities. Those descriptions need to remain attached to particular periods, not treated as one uninterrupted schedule for every day I spent in custody.

I remember missing the chance to go out because I had not heard an officer approaching or was not ready when he reached the door. I put a sign on my door because I wanted my recreation time.

Men made a song out of the phrase about having lost their recreation. We could laugh about it and still be upset. The joke did not mean the hour was unimportant. It was another way to respond to something we could not easily change.

I also remember an officer giving us an extra hour out. In my recollection, it doubled the time we had been getting on those days. That was why I remembered it so strongly.

That officer treated us with compassion. I have said that his treatment made me look beyond the religious and racial divisions I encountered in custody. What mattered was that he saw men who needed some time outside and responded to that need.

I am thankful for him. I remember what another hour outside the cell meant to me.

The Bag of Ice

Another officer regularly stopped to ask whether I was all right.

I talked to him about my children, and he talked about his. I remember those conversations because they allowed something from outside the jail into the encounter. We were talking about being fathers.

One night, it was hot and I could not sleep. When I recorded this memory, I placed it near the beginning of my time at the D.C. jail, probably in April 2021. That date is uncertain. I remembered it as an early period when we were spending most of our time in our cells.

I asked him for ice.

I had not had ice in months, as I remembered it. I was serious about wanting some, but I did not think he would actually bring it. The request was half a joke because I did not expect much to happen.

Near midnight, he came back with a small bag.

I nearly cried. That is what I said when I told the story. I was thankful that he had heard the request and returned with something I wanted.

The bag was small, but the act was clear. I had asked. He had gone away. Then he came back with it.

I remember feeling seen, heard, and comforted. Those are the words I used afterward. I associated his conduct with the compassion I valued in my faith. I did not need a speech from him. He had done something.

This memory stands on the act itself: an officer checking on me, a request I barely expected him to fulfill, and the small bag he brought back.

Remembering the Help

I want the good officers in this book because I remember them.

When I first began telling these stories, I was angry about what I had experienced. I still had many things I wanted people to understand. But the people who helped me were part of that same period, and I did not want anger to take their actions out of the account.

I remember extra time out of the cell. I remember someone checking on me. I remember speaking about children and receiving a bag of ice. Those memories are specific enough to return to. They are not a general claim that the conditions were fine.

A kind act could help me endure a day while leaving the larger problem unresolved. More recreation did not answer every complaint about confinement. Ice did not answer a request for treatment. A conversation did not decide my case.

They still mattered. They were things another person chose to do while I was in a position of needing help.

There is a written record of some of those relationships too. I kept five favorable officer evaluations dated August 12, August 17, August 24, September 1, and November 16, 2021. They gave me high marks while I was living in the jail. An officer named Franklin also described me as someone who helped other men and tried to calm problems.

Those records matter to me because they were made during the period I am describing. They do not mean that I never had a conflict or that every later allegation against me was false. They show that officers could know me through my daily conduct and put something favorable about it on paper.

The same man who could be grateful for an officer's kindness could continue writing grievances. There was no contradiction in that for me. I could recognize an act of care and still explain what I believed was wrong.

The forms I kept show some of those unresolved needs. They also show what the institution said in response. By April 2022, I was trying to explain in writing why being seen at an appointment had not meant that my request for help was resolved.

The people who helped me remain in my memory. The questions that needed more than a kind moment went onto the page.

13. Grievance Resolved

April 13

On April 13, 2022, I filled out another form about my mental health.

There was a question near the top asking whether the issue had been resolved. I marked no. Below it, I explained why the appointments listed in the earlier response had not answered my request.

The March 24 request appears at the beginning of this book. I had asked to be seen at mental health. The April 1 reply listed appointments on March 25 and March 30 and marked the grievance resolved. By April 13, I was trying to explain what those appointments had actually involved from my point of view.

I wrote that the March 25 contact lasted three to five minutes and was for scheduling an appointment with a therapist. I described the March 30 visit as lasting about ten minutes. I said I had spent most of that time talking about my PTSD and conditions of confinement.

I also wrote that the therapist told me there was no long-term mental-health therapy at the D.C. jail and that she would check on me again in two weeks. That was my account of the conversation, written shortly afterward. The page preserves what I reported; it is not a recording of her exact words.

I was not saying that nobody had seen me. I was distinguishing between a brief contact, an appointment, and the help I believed I still needed.

At the bottom, I continued beyond the main box. I wrote about being a Marine veteran with PTSD and needing more help than

ten minutes every two weeks. I had run out of the space provided before I had finished explaining myself.

The answer was dated April 20. Debra Jones recorded the response on behalf of Bruce Reid. It said I had been seen on March 25 and March 30 for evaluation and would have a follow-up appointment to discuss long-term therapy options. It again marked the grievance resolved.

There was an important difference between the two accounts on that page. I described the first contact as scheduling. The response described evaluation. I reported being told there was no long-term therapy. The response said the follow-up would address longer-term options.

The form did not make that difference disappear. It placed our accounts on the same sheet.

The Next Step

On April 21, I took the issue to the warden's administrative-remedy form.

I began by disagreeing again with the description of March 25 as an evaluation. I said it had been to schedule the March 30 therapist appointment. Then I wrote that three weeks had passed since that visit and I still had not received the check-in I had been expecting.

The need had continued while the forms moved. I reported that my conditions of confinement had become worse and were aggravating the anxiety and depression I associated with my diagnosed PTSD. I also wrote that my mental-health medication had not been delivered that morning despite repeated requests.

Those were things I was reporting about myself while I was there. I was trying to describe the change since the previous appointment, not merely repeat that I had once asked to be seen.

I also said I was in segregation and described what I believed had led to it. That part of the form contains my allegation about the reason for the placement. It should not be mistaken for a finding by an investigator or a judge.

The form had a place for the warden's answer. A deadline of May 13 was written above it. On the copy I kept, the later entry in that response area says: "No response, elevated to next level." The coordinator date is May 27.

That entry matters because it is more than an empty box. The copy records an unanswered stage being moved forward. It still cannot tell me whether another document exists somewhere else. It tells me what was recorded on the page I preserved.

When I look at it now, I can follow the request through the dates. March became April. April became May. I kept explaining why I believed I needed more help.

The paperwork was moving. My complaint was that the help I was asking for had not caught up with it.

A Final Level of Review

I prepared a deputy-director appeal dated May 15.

The printed form called it Step 4 and identified it as the final level of review within the Department of Corrections. I wrote that my April 21 request had not received a timely response and that I was escalating it.

I also reported having been on suicide precaution and leaving that unit on May 9. My records place me in NW1B that day and back in C2B on May 10. I asked again for mental-health help. I was describing a period in which my need felt urgent to me, and I wanted someone to review the earlier requests.

The response lines are blank on the copy in my archive. That is a limit of the copy, not proof that no reply was ever issued

anywhere. What it establishes is the appeal I prepared and what I was asking the department to address.

The larger record also includes contacts I reported having on April 27 and May 17. My later habeas petition acknowledged those brief encounters while disputing the adequacy of the help. Leaving them out would create the wrong impression that my claim was simply that nobody ever appeared.

My dispute was about what happened during those contacts and what remained afterward. I was asking for treatment that I felt I was not receiving. The institution recorded evaluations and follow-up plans. Those accounts need to remain distinguishable.

At another point, I alleged interference with the way an appeal had been handled. The department's written response disputed that allegation. It said staff could not find the altered document I described, asked me to provide a copy, and said the available information did not support intentional or malicious sabotage.

That answer belongs in the record too. Keeping the paperwork meant keeping the replies I disagreed with, not only the passages that supported me.

I did not experience the printed final level as the end of the need. I still wanted help, and I still wanted my account to be reviewed. The forms gave me a way to continue saying that in writing.

The Hours I Wrote Down

While I was pursuing those requests, another complaint concerned the water in my cell.

On May 2, 2022, I submitted an electronic grievance about the period from the previous afternoon into that morning. The preserved copy identifies my unit as SMU-A. It records an approximate start time of 2:45 p.m. on May 1 and an approximate restoration time of eleven in the morning on May 2.

I calculated the interval as twenty hours and fifteen minutes.

I wrote that I had been without access to drinking water and a flushable toilet. I said officers had turned off the water because of a concern involving the neighboring cell, and that my water had been shut off too.

The explanation about the neighboring cell was what I reported being told. I could describe my own lack of access and my requests. I could not see every decision behind the plumbing or know every conversation among staff.

That was why I put the hours and the explanation on the page. The event was still recent enough for me to record the times I remembered.

I used the word torture. That was my characterization in the complaint. I was trying to communicate the seriousness of what I believed had been done to me, including why I thought it was wrong for my water to be affected by a concern involving somebody else.

The duration is my contemporaneous report. It is not a utility log or a separate finding by the court. I do not need to turn it into either of those things to show what I wrote and why I continued asking for an answer.

The electronic submission had a date, time, response identifier, and a received stamp. Those details give this complaint a place in the sequence. They do not settle every disputed fact, but they keep the event from becoming only an undated memory.

I had also submitted an earlier electronic complaint. The May 2 form followed it. They concern the same water episode. Multiple forms in the archive do not make it multiple shutoffs.

A Copy for My Records

On May 10, I wrote about the water again by hand.

I identified the incident as May 1 through May 2. I described more than twenty hours without water in my cell and referred to the electronic grievance I had already submitted.

Then I explained why I was writing another one: I wanted a hard copy for my records, and I expected an answer to the electronic complaint.

That reason is on the page. It was not something added when I began assembling a book. I was preserving the issue while I was still in the jail.

The complaint was received on May 12. The response says the incident was being investigated. A staff date of May 16 and coordinator date of May 17 appear below it.

That was an answer about the status of an investigation. It was not a final account of what happened, an admission of every allegation, or an explanation of why my water had been turned off.

There were later forms about the same issue. I continued asking about the electronic complaints and the response. A formal grievance was marked non-grievable with an attachment referring back to the existing grievance. That attachment did not say water deprivation could never be grieved. It treated this submission as an issue already addressed under another number.

The distinction matters because I was keeping a trail, not simply collecting the harshest words from each page. There was the event I described, the first submissions, the decision to make a paper copy, the investigation response, and the later attempts to obtain an answer.

I have the paper now. I can see where I wrote beyond a box, where a response was added, and where another step began. The pages preserve the work it took to keep a request alive.

I did not have a chapter called “Grievance Resolved” then. I had a need, an answer I did not believe resolved it, and another place to write.

The hard copy was something I could keep. It let me carry the record beyond the exchange at the cell door and, eventually, beyond the jail.

14. Taking the Record Outside

What Was on the Tablet

One of the pages I kept was dated March 9, 2022. It concerned the APDS tablet.

I wrote that discovery had been provided on the tablets and that I wanted my investigative attorney added so I could share the information with my legal team. I referred to a request I had made on March 7 and said it had been denied.

That is the specific problem the page records. There was material on the tablet. I was asking for a way to work on it with someone helping with my case.

When I think about that period, I remember the frustration of trying to prepare my case. The form gives that frustration a specific shape. I had material to review, and I wanted to share it with someone helping me.

When asked how the request worked, I remembered an add-attorney function and a request form. I thought I had been told the request was denied, but I could not confidently identify the exact message, person, or delivery method. I also recalled explanations about eligibility that felt like a runaround to me.

The tablet belonged to the jail. The grievance was a record I could keep. I had put down the date of the request and what I was asking to do.

Learning the Library

The tablet also belongs to a separate memory: learning to use the law library.

I have placed the arrival of the clear tablets around May 2021, with uncertainty about the date. I remember preloaded material and a law library. I also remember evidence becoming available through the system.

The records describe more than one kind of device. My March grievance concerned the APDS tablet and adding an attorney. Later discovery complaints concerned laptops used to open drives. A problem with one device did not mean the other was unavailable for every purpose. What mattered was whether I could reach the material I needed and work on it with my lawyers.

It did not work like the computer I was accustomed to using outside. In my later account, I described a different layout, a slower system, and the time it took to learn how to search. Sometimes a tablet was dead. Sometimes access was interrupted. Being handed a device was not the same as already knowing how to use it.

I began reading cases and the Constitution. I was looking for language that could help me understand what was happening and describe what I believed was wrong.

There was a practical change in that. I could write that something was wrong, but I also wanted to identify the event, the date, the request, the response, and the reason I thought it mattered. The forms and the reading began to work together.

Other men were studying too. We talked about evidence and divided up material to watch. I remember bringing back what we had found and comparing notes. There was more to review than I could quickly get through by myself.

We also drew conclusions from what we watched. Some of those conclusions were allegations or interpretations, and some were later disputed in court. Working through footage together did not make every inference correct.

What I can say about the habit is that I kept reading and recording. I wanted to understand more of my own case and the conditions under which I was trying to prepare it.

I was still a person in custody. Learning the words did not make me a lawyer. It gave me another way to ask for an answer.

The Petition

On August 10, 2022, my lawyers filed a separate habeas petition.

It was filed as Nichols v. Garland, case 1:22-cv-02356, in the District of Columbia. The petition asked for release and other relief based on the conditions being challenged.

The document gathered matters I had been trying to raise from inside: prolonged isolation, mental-health treatment, access to counsel and discovery, and retaliation. It connected allegations with dates, grievance steps, and exhibits.

The care-request sequence appeared there. The petition described the March request, the appointments, the April grievance and appeal, and the later contacts and complaints. Pages I had been keeping inside the jail became part of a presentation to a court.

That was important to me. In my recorded account of learning the law, I connected the grievances with my effort to get out. I believed documenting what was happening gave me a way to challenge it.

My lawyers were asking the court to accept our account and act on it. The petition set out our claims and the relief we wanted. We were still seeking a decision.

It was a serious attempt to take the issues outside the jail. I had been writing requests and appeals. My lawyers put the claims into a separate case.

A Conversation I Wrote Down

On August 26, 2022, I wrote down a conversation with a member of the U.S. Marshals Service about the grievance process. Two other prisoners signed the page as witnesses.

My account says he confirmed that a report about problems with the process existed. When we asked when it would be available, I recorded him saying it had gone above his head.

The signed page preserves what we said we heard. It is not the report itself. I was still trying to get the problems I had been writing about in front of someone who could act on them.

A Change of Facility

The transfer to Rappahannock Regional Jail came on September 12, 2022. I have sometimes remembered that move as August or September. The saved correspondence puts a date on it.

At 3:15 that afternoon, my lawyer Jonathan Gross emailed Marshal Lamont Ruffin. He said neither my lawyers nor my family had been given information about a possible transfer. He had contacted the D.C. jail's lawyer and been directed to the Marshals.

At 5:10, Ruffin replied that I had been moved to Rappahannock that day. He said the court had been informed and that transportation details were not discussed until a move was complete. Gross continued asking what authorized the transfer and what information the court had received.

I was in another jail. By October, the practical question of reviewing evidence was still being argued over.

In an October 19 filing in the criminal case, the government said Rappahannock did not allow inmates to review electronic discovery on drives outside attorney visits. It also said it would

not oppose a transfer to a facility that could provide that review if the Marshals and facilities could accommodate it.

The government was describing a restriction that mattered to my preparation. Having evidence stored at a facility did not mean I could sit down and review it when I needed to.

My lawyers were also arguing about property and drives. They raised concerns that legal material had been taken and might have been accessed or copied. The government disputed those claims. A D.C. jail employee described the handling and return of a drive and denied copying it. The prosecution denied having received or reviewed the material.

Those filings do not establish that someone copied the drives. They preserve a dispute about access, handling, and what happened while the property was outside my control. I wanted the material back and wanted to be able to use it. That need was clear even where the explanations conflicted.

A drive could be in the facility's possession and still be unavailable to me outside an attorney visit. Changing facilities had not ended that problem.

On October 17, I asked Rappahannock for access to a computer so I could review evidence.com and Relativity and use the discovery drive I had brought from D.C. The answer said the request had to go to the Marshals first. If they approved it, the jail would see whether it could accommodate it.

I filed a grievance on October 26. I said Judge Hogan had directed that I be able to review my discovery, and I asked again for access. The return form treated the issue as jail operations and said I had not supplied the required earlier request or its number. It also offered a different route: have my attorney send paper copies through the mail.

I was asking to work with electronic evidence. The reply sent me back through a procedure and offered paper copies. I kept both the request and the answer.

The outside case had not made the daily process simple. I was still trying to work on a criminal case from custody, and another facility had its own rules.

What Happened to the Habeas Case

The habeas petition was withdrawn.

My lawyers filed a notice of voluntary dismissal on October 7, 2022. In an October 28 filing in the criminal case, they explained their position: the transfer had mooted the action against the D.C. jail. The withdrawal ended that effort without a ruling proving the conditions I had challenged.

My criminal case continued. My lawyers continued arguing for release there, and the release order came in November.

The court had denied an earlier request to modify bail in December 2021. It said the showing then made did not establish the due-process violation we asserted. The court had expressed concern about conditions during a hearing, but that request had still been denied.

I still wanted the conditions addressed. A denied request or a withdrawn petition did not remove what I was trying to explain. I carried forward the requests, the replies, and the record of the effort to get someone outside the jail to act.

On November 22, 2022, the court ordered my release with conditions. My lawyers and family picked me up that day, according to counsel's later filing. I would be home while the criminal case continued.

The door out of custody had opened. It did not open onto the same freedom I had known before the arrest.

Part IV. Sentence and Prison

15. Home, With Conditions

Home Incarceration

I came home before I was sentenced.

When I tell the years quickly, that period can disappear between arrest and prison. It was a different part of the experience. I had been detained, I was released to my home with restrictions, and I later went back into custody while the criminal case continued.

The release order was dated November 22, 2022. My lawyer's later filing says my family and counsel picked me up from jail that day.

The order selected home incarceration. It restricted me to the residence except for medical necessities, court appearances, and activities specifically approved by the court. It also required location monitoring and supervision.

There was a specific exception for Sunday church. I could leave within the stated hours, go directly to the named church, and return directly home. I was not allowed to use that trip as permission to go somewhere else.

Those details matter to the meaning of being home. I was outside the jail and with my family, but I had not returned to deciding where to go in the way I had before the arrest. Ordinary movement remained subject to conditions.

There were restrictions on contact with people involved in the case and on access to weapons. There were directions about treatment and medication. The order also placed responsibilities on the household, including limits on internet-capable devices.

The criminal case was still there. Coming through the door at home did not mean the charges were dismissed or that I knew how the case would end.

I had wanted to get out of jail. I had worked toward that through grievances, records, and motions. Being home was a real change. It was also another situation I had to learn how to live in.

People Who Came to the House

People at church came to know us during that period too.

Wayne Taylor, who attended our Sunday school class, later wrote that he remembered Bonnie and me seeming uncomfortable when we first came. He thought we were worried that people would not want us there once they knew about the case. He wrote that the class wanted us to feel welcome and that he visited our home several times to talk with me.

Rodney LaJoie, a small-group teacher, wrote to the court on April 22, 2024. He said he had personally heard me express regret for my actions and take responsibility for them. He asked for mercy at sentencing.

Their letters described a part of that year that was easy to leave out of the court chronology: a class we attended, people who welcomed us, and conversations that continued at home while the case was still pending.

A Document and a Spreadsheet

The internet restrictions affected how I worked on my case.

The November order allowed internet use for reviewing discovery and communicating with counsel, limited to specified sites. It did not give me ordinary unrestricted access. It also required the household's other internet-capable devices to be password protected, with the passwords withheld from me.

On January 3, 2023, the court added a narrow permission: I could use Google Docs and Google Sheets to share documents and spreadsheets with my attorney in preparation for trial.

That sounds like a small technical change. In the context of trying to organize a case, it meant permission to use two familiar ways of putting information where the person helping me could see it.

I had spent time in custody trying to understand the law library, review material, and record what I thought mattered. At home, access was still governed by an order. The setting was different, but I could not treat a computer as something I was simply free to use.

I did not always follow those conditions. I used the internet when I was not supposed to. I have said that in my recordings, and it belongs here too.

The orders gave me limited permission, and that permission expanded in January. I was frustrated with the restrictions and wanted to keep looking for information.

I wanted to keep working on the evidence and the questions I still had. That desire did not change the conditions I was supposed to follow. I crossed those limits, and that belongs in the story too.

Preparing for a Case

In March 2023, my lawyer asked for more time before trial.

He wrote that I had looked noticeably different when they picked me up in November. He described continuing problems with my physical and mental health and asked for more time to prepare.

I did not come home and simply resume everything as it had been. I still had the criminal case to face and questions I wanted answered.

The People I Wanted Answers About

Two of those questions went back to people I associated with rescue work.

One was a person I knew through Zello as 1% Watchdog. The other was Marcus DiPaola, the reporter I had met during Hurricane Florence.

In my recordings, I describe Watchdog as a voice involved in directing people toward rescues. Zello let people talk to each other while work was happening in different places. That was the setting in which I came to trust the voice behind that name.

Marcus was connected to a rescue that became part of my public life. I had known him before January 6 became the event by which so many people knew me.

When I later looked back at the conversations before the trip to Washington, those earlier connections mattered to me. I remember Marcus recommending body armor. I remember Watchdog talking about weapons and what he expected to happen. I have described a long phone conversation in which I disagreed with violent things he was saying.

Those are my recollections of the conversations. I wanted to know who I had been listening to and whether anybody had been directing them.

I also need to keep my own decision in the story. In my account of the days leading up to January 6, I say I wanted to go when I saw President Trump's post. I began talking about going before the calls I describe. Other people's words mattered to me, but they did not erase the decisions I made.

In June 2023, my lawyers put the questions into court filings. They asked for information about people we suspected might have government connections, including Watchdog and Marcus. The requests included interview reports, communications, and

records that might establish what a relationship with the government actually was.

That distinction mattered. Knowing a person, receiving information from a person, and directing that person to influence somebody are different things. I wanted the records behind my suspicions.

The government's written response came in July. It said it was aware of a Zello user called 1% Watchdog. It said material about that individual had been disclosed, including in another January 6 case, and referred to an August 2022 email to my lawyer. It also said it was aware of Marcus DiPaola and had complied, and would continue to comply, with its disclosure obligations concerning him.

Our reply acknowledged the prior Watchdog disclosure. My lawyers argued that it was inadequate and described the explanation they had received as a dead end at a foreign website.

That was the dispute in those papers. The government said it had met its obligations. We said the response had not answered what we needed to know. The written response did not say the government had never heard of either person.

On October 16, 2023, the court denied the discovery motions. On the alleged-informant requests, the judge said the allegations depended on conjecture and that I had not shown how the requested information would provide material evidence for my defense.

In my later recordings, I describe feeling manipulated. The court did not find that I had been entrapped. My account of those conversations remains part of the story, alongside my own decision to go and what I later signed in the criminal case.

I did not get the outcome I wanted from that litigation. I still had questions, and I still had to decide how to face the case.

The ruling concerned disclosure and the demands presented to the court. The practical problem of getting access to discovery while in jail, recorded on my March 2022 complaint, was a separate part of what I had experienced.

Being home had changed where I lived. It had not ended the decisions waiting for me.

The Plea and the Return

On November 7, 2023, I pleaded guilty.

The contemporaneous announcement identifies two felony offenses: obstruction of an official proceeding and assaulting, resisting, or impeding certain officers. Judge Royce Lamberth accepted the plea and remanded me to custody.

The later signed judgment records the guilty pleas to both counts, including the assault offense.

There was also a statement of offense bearing my signature and my lawyers' signatures, dated October 2, 2023. That date was before the October 16 discovery ruling. I signed it more than a month before the plea hearing; it was filed on November 8.

In that statement, I admitted obstructing the proceeding and assaulting officers with pepper spray in a way that created a substantial risk of serious bodily injury. I also acknowledged that I acted of my own accord at the Capitol and had not been tricked, cajoled, or forced into that conduct.

That was my signed admission. My later account of feeling manipulated does not change what the document says. Both have to remain visible when I explain the case.

I remember not wanting to plead guilty. I wanted answers before trial and felt that I could not prove what I wanted to prove. That was the pressure I felt as I faced the decision. I entered the plea, and the court accepted it.

The period at home had ended. I had gone from detention to home incarceration, spent months with the criminal case still pending, and returned after the guilty plea. Sentencing was still ahead.

I had spent part of those years in a jail cell and part at home under conditions. They were different kinds of restriction, and both had shaped my life. Now I was returning to custody after my own guilty plea.

I was back in custody, waiting for the court to decide the punishment.

Back Through the Requests

Going back into custody also meant asking for care again.

A January 3, 2024 grievance describes being taken to an appointment the day before and having it canceled when I arrived. I wrote that it was the second such cancellation in fifteen days. I suspected appointments were being put on paper without the treatment reaching me.

The institution's January 10 answer said I had received the medication on January 4 and had been seen at sick call. That answer belongs with the complaint. It records care after the canceled appointment, even though it did not settle everything I was raising.

In March, I challenged another kind of entry. Records described missed appointments as refusals or no-shows. In grievances dated March 8 and March 15, I said I had not refused to go. I said no officer had come to collect me, despite my requests.

A March 5 clinical entry said an officer had not obtained a signed refusal. That detail did not settle every missed appointment. It did show why I kept disputing the label. A record saying I did not appear could not, by itself, explain why I had not reached the provider.

I was still doing the thing I had learned to do in custody: put down the date, say what I had asked for, and keep the response. Sentencing was getting closer. The daily requests continued.

16. Sixty-Three Months

Before the Number

Before the judge gave me a number, he heard from my family.

Their voices reached the courtroom through videos. Judge Lamberth said he had watched them all that morning. He called them powerful. The government questioned whether my remorse had come too late and pointed out that many of the character letters had been written back in 2021. The judge answered by talking about the people who knew me. My father had impressed him. Dad believed I had changed.

Those were different views of the same man. The prosecutor described the violence and the words I had used before, during, and after January 6. My family described the man they knew and hoped would come home. Both accounts were before the judge.

My attorney asked for time served. The government asked for eighty-three months. Before those arguments, the court had worked through a dispute over the sentencing calculation and settled on a guideline range of fifty-one to sixty-three months. The prosecution wanted more time than that range. My lawyer wanted me released.

When my turn came, I began with something small. I apologized for my appearance. I told the judge that the clippers had not come in and that I had wanted to stand before him clean-shaven and clean-cut.

I told the judge I had brought papers to read from.

I apologized to the people hurt by January 6. I included the officers, members of Congress, peaceful protesters, their families, and people in Washington. I told the court that my

words and actions had caused pain. I acknowledged assaulting an officer and said the officer had not deserved it.

I also told the judge what I was afraid of losing beyond the time in custody. I had worked beside law enforcement and first responders during rescues. Now I did not know whether they would ever trust me to work alongside them again. Saving a life had been one of the most fulfilling things I knew how to do. I wanted the chance to earn my way back to that work.

And I talked about my sons. The games. The first days of school. Birthdays and ordinary days I had missed. I told the court I could work for a lifetime and still not make up that time.

I asked to come home. I said I wanted to help people returning from incarceration find their place in the community. I wanted another chance to contribute to my family and to the people around me.

The court took a short recess.

When we came back, the judge imposed sixty-three months. He said I appeared sincere, while also explaining his concern about the statements he had seen and heard across the case. He declined to go above or below the guideline range.

I had spoken. My family had spoken. My lawyer had asked for mercy.

The sentence still meant more prison.

The Sentence on the Page

On May 2, 2024, the court sentenced me to sixty-three months in prison.

The signed judgment sets out the sentence for the two counts to which I had pleaded guilty. The terms were concurrent. That meant the judgment imposed a total prison term of sixty-three

months, not two consecutive terms adding up to twice that amount.

The first count was obstruction of an official proceeding and aiding and abetting. The second was assaulting, resisting, or impeding certain officers. The judgment records both and states that the remaining counts were dismissed on the government's motion.

Sixty-three months was the sentence imposed. I had already lived through detention, home incarceration, and the return to jail after my plea. The number on the judgment did not describe all those different days. It told me the prison term I now faced.

I have spoken about the sentence with anger. I have also mixed some of its financial amounts together when telling the story. Going back to the signed judgment gives each part its proper place.

The written judgment was filed on May 5. The sentencing itself had taken place on May 2.

I had the result: sixty-three months, and another stage of custody ahead.

More Than the Prison Term

The judgment also imposed thirty-six months of supervised release.

That was separate from the prison term. The sentence had conditions for the period after imprisonment as well as punishment to be served in custody.

There were financial penalties too: a two-hundred-thousand-dollar fine, two thousand dollars in restitution, and a two-hundred-dollar assessment. The total was two hundred two thousand two hundred dollars, but it was not all a fine.

When I talked about the money afterward, I sometimes put it all together. The judgment separates the fine, restitution, and assessment. Each was another part of the sentence I had to face.

The judge also gave a reason for the fine. He said I had not shown that I was unable to pay and referred to the presentence report's account that I had declined to cooperate with the financial investigation. My lawyer objected to the sentencing calculation and the corresponding fine. That was the explanation and objection recorded in the hearing.

I was angry about what the case had cost me and my family. When I spoke about the money afterward, that anger came with it.

The page gives the terms. The work of understanding their place in my life continued after the hearing.

Where I Would Go

The court recommended that I be placed at FCI Seagoville.

It was a recommendation to the Bureau of Prisons. I remember the journey ending at Beaumont instead, after other facilities along the way.

I knew from the earlier moves that a transfer could be difficult. I had already experienced waiting to learn where I was going and trying to keep family informed. Leaving one place did not mean I knew how long it would take to reach the next.

In the recording about federal prison, I called transfer both a good time and a scary time. It could feel like going to the next step, but I did not know what would happen along the way.

The recommendation did not give me the experience of the journey in advance. I still had to be moved, processed, and placed wherever the system took me.

A week after sentencing, in the sequence I remember, that movement began. I knew the prison term. I still did not know the places I would pass through before reaching the one where I would serve it.

17. Con Air

The Knock in the Night

The officer came to the door around three in the morning. I needed a COVID test. I was leaving.

I remember that officer as one of the good ones. He let me call home before they moved me. I could tell my wife that I was going, but I could not tell her exactly where I would end up. I did not know.

I had been sentenced on May 2, 2024. I remember starting that trip into federal prison on May 9. There were vans, buses, aircraft, holding cells, and places where I would have to wait for the next move. Each time somebody called my name, I had to go. Knowing my sentence did not mean I knew what would happen to me that day.

Leaving Washington did not feel like finishing something. I was leaving a place whose routines I had learned for places I knew through stories from other men. I had heard enough to be scared, and too little to know how much of what I had heard would apply to me.

On the bus, men talked about the time they had left. Some were facing years that made my sentence sound short. I still had a family at home, and the time separating us did not feel short to me. But I listened. I was new to this part of the system, and these men knew things I did not.

One lesson kept coming up: mind your business. Pay attention, but do not get caught paying the wrong kind of attention. I could understand those words before I understood what living by them would require.

Lewisburg

Lewisburg looked like a castle to me. Brick, wire, a tower. It was an old place built to keep people inside, and I felt that as soon as I saw it.

Most of the men went one way. A few of us went another. I was put in a small holding cage with hardly enough room to move. I had already had dreams about being confined in a space like that. Standing there, I remembered them. That recognition made an already frightening place feel even stranger.

The cell I went to had bars. That was different from the doors I had known in D.C. There were fans, but I remember the heat. I also remember being worn out. I had been awake through the move, and I wanted to sleep.

A man prayed through the night. I lay there listening. The next morning, breakfast came, and the cells opened for a period on the tier. I took my tray back into my cell.

I was still trying to understand where I was. I did not know the men around me, their relationships, or what might have happened between them before I arrived. I had no history in that building. Whatever had been developing there would be new to me when I saw it.

That was the morning I learned how quickly an ordinary object could become something I would remember for the rest of my life.

The Fire Extinguisher

I heard a commotion and looked out. A man had taken a fire extinguisher.

I heard the first blow. I saw the second. The sound reminded me of a hammer hitting a brick wall. There were gasps around me. I

was watching a man being hit in the head with something that was supposed to be hanging there for a fire.

The injured man fought back and got the extinguisher away from him. The other man ran into a cell and closed himself inside. I remember blood on the injured man's hands as he tried to get at the bars. The violence had moved, but it had not become less frightening.

My first instinct was to go toward the door and get an officer. An older prisoner stopped me. The message was the same one I had heard on the bus: mind your business.

This time, I understood what he was asking me to do. A man was bleeding, and I was being told to stay out of it. I went back. I was scared of what would happen if I became part of the incident. I was also scared by how quickly I had been made to choose.

It felt like a long time before officers came. In my memory it was roughly twenty minutes, though I was not standing there with a clock measuring it. When they arrived, there was blood and a fire extinguisher, and then there was a lockdown.

An officer questioned me because he had seen me near the door. I said I had not seen anything.

That is part of the story too. I do not get to describe the violence and leave out what I did afterward. I had seen it. I had heard it. I was afraid, and I denied seeing it.

I did not see that man die. I do not know what happened to him afterward. What I know is what happened in front of me, and what it did to the way I carried myself. Before breakfast, minding my business had been advice. Afterward, it had a sound attached to it.

I remember the days there as a stretch when I could not use the phone. I sent a letter. My family was living through things at home that I wanted to be there for, and even finding out how they were doing could become impossible for days at a time.

Then my name was called again. I had to leave the place where I had just learned that lesson and take it with me to the next one.

Charlie Brown

After the flight to Oklahoma City, officers pulled me to the front of a long line. There was a platform with several places for men to stand while they were searched and their chains were removed. I remember being up there by myself with six officers in front of me.

I did not know why I had been brought forward. I knew that I was being handled separately, and that was enough to make me nervous.

I went into special housing. In another small holding space, I listened to men talk about sentences and destinations far beyond anything I had expected for my own life. I did not feel like telling my story. I had months left to think about; some of them were talking about decades.

Eventually I shared a cell with a man called Charlie Brown.

For about a week, we had time to talk. A lot of time. We ate together. We prayed together. We talked about our families, where we had come from, and where we were going. I was headed toward Beaumont, and he tried to prepare me for it.

I had been scared of being placed in another cell with somebody I did not know. In the days we shared, Charlie talked to me and helped me understand what might be ahead.

He also helped me make a phone call.

When the phone came around, I thought the instructions meant I could not use it. I was prepared to leave it alone. Charlie told me to come over and try. I was still caught up in what might happen if I got it wrong.

I used the phone. I called home and spoke with my wife. Charlie spoke with his family too. The phone stayed with us long enough for both of us to talk before it was collected.

It was a simple thing from the outside. Two men made calls. From inside that cell, it mattered. I had spent days unable to hear from home, and there was suddenly a voice on the other end.

Charlie talked with me about family history too. He made me think about how much I did not know about my own. We were men waiting to be moved, with our belongings reduced to what the system allowed us to keep, and we could still talk about where we came from.

I got called to leave before he did. The cell we had shared had been another stop. He stayed, and I went south.

Texas Through the Window

I remember a red moon on that bus ride. I remember the color and looking at it from the bus.

Then there was Texas in daylight. Roads I knew. Dallas buildings I recognized. I had traveled those roads with my family, going between the places that made up our lives. Now I was seeing them in restraints, headed to prison.

The road had not become strange. My place on it had.

I watched other men look at the skyline. Some had not seen it before. For a little while, we had something outside the bus to look at that was more than another fence or holding area. I could recognize home in what was passing us, but we were not stopping there.

I remember arriving at Beaumont on July 1, 2024. The bus stopped at the penitentiary first. I was going to the medium security facility. I had heard men talk about Beaumont all through the trip, and when we got there, the bus was quiet.

I was sick and tired by then. I did not know the layout. I did not know what kind of room I would get or who would be living in it. I knew only that the moving was ending for the moment and that I would have to learn another place.

Inside, officers removed the restraints and began the questions and processing. Beyond that were the dorms and the yard.

Charlie had tried to prepare me. The men on the buses had given me their warnings. At Lewisburg, I had already seen how frightening an open cell door could become.

Now I had arrived.

18. The Yard

Learning Where I Was

At Beaumont, I would wake up sweating around six in the morning. That was about as cool as our room was going to get. I had come through weeks of movement and holding cells, and now I had a place to stay. I still did not know how to live there.

The room assignment was not simple. Men were talking about who would live where and who would agree to it. I spent the first part of my arrival waiting for that to settle. Then I was taken to meet the man who would become my cellmate.

We called him GW.

Before I moved in, there was a conversation about how he lived. He asked whether his prayer practices would bother me. They would not. I was looking for a place to sleep and get through my time. Other things came up, including his drug use. I said I was all right with things I did not yet understand.

I had never lived in a cell with somebody whose day could be organized around getting high in that way. I heard a question and thought I understood what I was agreeing to. Living with him taught me otherwise.

I also made a choice about who I would run with. I attached myself to GW because I believed being with him would keep me out of some of the fights and demands around me. I was hoping to go home. I did not want to add years to my sentence trying to prove something on a prison yard.

That was the calculation I made. It did not make the cell safe.

Sharing a Room with Fear

I was used to trying to read people. With GW, I could not get comfortable with what I was reading.

He stayed in the cell a lot, even when the doors were open. When he did go out, other men noticed him. I watched their reactions because I was trying to understand whether the fear I felt was just mine. From what I saw, other people were careful around him too.

His mood could change with what he had and what he needed. I remember good stretches when he was high and had enough drugs. I remember the tension when he was running short or something he used was not working. I began paying attention to those changes because I lived in the same small room.

I was using drugs too. I cannot tell this as though I watched all of it from a clean distance. I got caught up in the buying, trading, and daily effort to keep things coming. I used meth in prison. I used Suboxone. What had once been somebody else's way of getting through a day became part of mine.

There were things I told myself I would not do, and I held to some of them. But pointing to a line I did not cross did not erase the lines I had already crossed. I was becoming somebody I did not like.

At first, there was even a part of me that thought I was handling it. I could tell myself I was living a hard life and learning how to survive it. I would not be there forever. I could get through it and go home.

What I did not understand was how much of that life I was taking into myself. I was learning to watch for danger, to keep fear off my face, and to accept things that would once have stopped me cold. Those changes did not announce themselves all at once.

The Corner

There was a time GW expected me to help him if a confrontation turned violent. We went to another man's cell. Before we went, he told me what part I was supposed to play. If there was a fight, I was to help hold the other man while GW attacked him.

I went with him. I stood where he told me to stand.

I did not want it to happen. I also did not tell GW that I refused. In my head, I was thinking about how badly it could go, and about what would happen if I disappointed him. I was afraid that the anger could turn toward me.

The men talked. I stood in the corner while they worked it out with words. There was a knife on the desk, and I was looking at a situation that I did not want to become part of. It ended without the attack I had been told to help carry out.

I was relieved. That does not turn me into the person who stopped it. I did not stop it. They talked, and the violence did not happen.

The part I have to own is that I went there and stood in the corner. Whatever I was saying to myself about not wanting trouble, I had put myself in a position where somebody expected me to help hurt another person.

I wanted to believe that staying close to GW would let me finish my time without getting pulled into something like that. Instead, I was discovering that being close to him came with expectations of its own.

The Missing Suboxone

The confrontation with the knife at my throat happened in our cell during a lockdown. It was a different incident.

My Suboxone was missing. I remembered having it in the cell before the doors closed, and then I could not find it. There were

only two of us in a small space, and I kept looking through the places where it could have been.

I suspected GW might have picked it up. I did not see him take it. I was trying to keep my frustration to myself because I knew who I was locked in with. I am not good at hiding everything I feel, though. I got quiet, and the quiet became part of the argument.

I remember him asking, “You think I stole it?”

I told him I had not said that. I wanted to know where it had gone. He kept coming back to whether I was accusing him, and I kept trying to explain why I was frustrated.

I was on my bunk. After we had gone back and forth, I jumped down. I wanted to talk about it. I was venting. To me, coming off the bunk was part of finally getting the frustration out. From the way he reacted, he took it as a move toward a fight.

He grabbed the knife and came up to me. He held it at my throat and threatened to kill me.

For a split second, I thought about grabbing him and the knife. Then I knew I did not want to turn that thought into a movement. I did not want a fight for my life in that cell. I wanted to go home to my family.

The knife was there, and there was no room for me to pretend I was unafraid. I was scared as hell. I was also trying not to show that fear in a way I thought might make things worse. I believed that reaching for the knife could get me hurt, and I believed that looking as though I was about to attack could do the same.

I kept my hands away from it and talked. I told him I was not trying to fight him. I was not accusing him. I was upset because I could not find my own stuff.

Then I began taking the blame for losing it. I told him I was angry with myself. I apologized for making it seem as though I was accusing him. I remember trying to speak calmly while also speaking fast enough to keep the words going.

I had been thinking about missing drugs. Now I was thinking about whether one movement would keep me from ever seeing my children again. The difference between those two things was right there at my throat.

When the Distance Opened

GW moved backward first.

I stayed where I was until he moved away. Then I could move backward too. That is how I remember the space opening between us. I did not take the knife from him. I did not win a fight. I kept talking, and he stepped back.

I believe he listened to what I was saying. I could see him calming as I kept telling him I did not want to fight. I could not know every thought going through his mind. I knew what I was trying to do and what happened next: the distance opened, and the encounter ended without him stabbing me.

The missing Suboxone turned up later. I still had my suspicions. I had not seen him take it, and I had not seen him put it back. Finding it did not answer every question about where it had been.

It also did not take away what had happened while it was missing.

When people talk about what they would do if someone pulled a knife, I think about that cell. I had ideas about defending myself too. Then I was there, and I was thinking about everything at once: my family, my remaining time, the danger in front of me, and what another confrontation might cost.

I had wanted the argument to stop. Once it stopped, I still shared a room with the man who had held the knife. I could not make the memory disappear because the immediate danger had passed.

What I Recognized in Him

During another lockdown, GW went without the Suboxone he was used to having. I watched him shiver and shake. I watched him ask for help. The man I feared could become miserable and desperate in front of me.

That changed how I saw him. He had told me how to carry myself and what not to show. Now I was seeing him unable to keep up that same front. Later, when he had drugs again, I watched the way he carried himself change again.

I began noticing a pattern. I also began noticing myself in it.

I had my own drug use. My own fears. I was changing with the room and the yard around me. I could recognize that he was putting on a certain face and still realize I had been learning to do something similar.

Some of that understanding came in prison. Some came after I moved to the low. Some came after I got out. It was an accumulation of moments, not a single morning when everything became clear.

I had once thought that staying near him might make my time easier. Later, I looked at the person I was becoming and did not like what I saw. That made it harder to keep respecting the way he lived just because it seemed to keep people away from him.

The knife was the moment I can describe most clearly. The rest was daily life: watching moods, waiting through lockdowns, using drugs, and trying to make it to the end of my sentence. I survived the confrontation. I was still living with what survival was asking of me.

19. People Behind the Doors

A Connection I Did Not Expect

On the day I arrived at Beaumont, before I learned the room and the yard, a caseworker closed her office door and asked me to sit down.

I remember her telling me, “You don't know me, but I know you.”

I asked how. She knew about the hurricane rescues. She told me I had worked with her husband during rescue work in the Beaumont area.

I had come through intake expecting more questions about my charges, my paperwork, and where I could be housed. Instead, somebody was talking to me about a part of my life that had nothing to do with being a prisoner. She knew me as a man who had gone down there to help.

I had not known that connection existed. I had gone to flooded communities to work, and later I had arrived in the same part of Texas in restraints. Those two parts of my life met in her office.

She looked at my paperwork and talked about trying to move me toward a halfway house and home confinement. As I remember it, she hoped it could happen within weeks. She explained that there was paperwork to send through and things that had to be done.

I was ecstatic. I asked questions about my time and the credits I thought applied to me. She said she would help. I was hearing a possibility of home on the day I had arrived at the place I had been dreading.

I thought, Thank you, Lord.

After everything I had heard about Beaumont, that conversation was the last thing I expected. I believed she wanted to help me, and I was grateful to have her as my caseworker.

A Call from Her Office

She told me to come see her after I got over to the dorm. She would let me call my wife.

I went back later, and I made that call. I remember the caseworker telling my wife that she was working to get me home. We got excited together.

I had been trying to ration my phone minutes so I would have some left to speak with my family every day. In my mind, I was dividing them into about fifteen minutes a day. That was not enough to make a marriage and fatherhood happen over a phone, but it was what I was trying to make work.

This call was different because somebody there was talking to us about what could come next. I did not have to be the only person on the line trying to explain the place or figure out the paperwork. My wife could hear the caseworker herself.

The hope was real. So was the fact that I was still at Beaumont afterward. I returned to the dorm, and the days there became the days I have described: the room, the heat, the lockdowns, and life with GW.

When I remember that caseworker, I remember somebody who offered help when I was expecting none. She had a job inside that institution, and she still saw a person sitting in front of her. That meant something to me.

Going Next Door

Later, after the 2024 election, I was called to her office again. This time, she told me I was going to the low security facility next door.

I did not want to go.

That sounds hard to explain after everything that had happened at the medium. I had been frightened there. I had lived through the confrontation in the cell. I was using drugs. I wanted to get out of prison. Yet when she told me I would be leaving that part of it, I argued.

I had learned that place. I knew people. I knew how my day worked there, even when the way it worked was bad for me. Going next door meant entering another place I did not know.

I even told her I could get written up. I was thinking that if I got in trouble, I might stop the move. She told me that would not change it. I was going.

I remember talking to GW about it too. He knew my paperwork and my time were different from his. I was trying to stay in a place I had been trying to survive, and he could see the contradiction even while I was arguing with it.

I did not immediately understand how much that resistance said about me. The room and the yard had become familiar. Familiar had started to matter more than whether staying there was good for me.

I moved to the low after that. My memory is of roughly another week or two before the transfer. It was a move within Beaumont, but it put distance between me and the room I had shared with GW.

A Different Kind of Space

The low had a different daily rhythm. There were cubicles and more movement. I could get up and go to the bathroom without the same arrangement of a locked cell door controlling it. Small differences felt large after the medium.

I was glad later that I had gone. I was not well when I got there. I was still dealing with drug use and trying to get myself together. Moving did not finish that work for me, but it changed the place where I had to begin doing it.

It also let me look back at the medium from somewhere outside that room. Some of what I had accepted with GW became clearer once I was no longer sharing the same space with him every day. I could see the way I had been changing and how much I had started to accept as ordinary.

I am grateful that the caseworker kept the move going when I resisted it. At the time, I thought I knew what I wanted. I wanted to stay with what I knew until I could go home. From the low, I could see that leaving the medium had mattered before I was ready to admit it.

The caseworker's office, Charlie's cell, and the room with GW all belong to my memory of federal prison. So does the officer who let me make a call before I left D.C. I met people who frightened me and people who helped me. Sometimes the help was a phone call. Sometimes it was a move I argued against.

I was still in custody. I was still waiting to go home. But I was no longer in that room with GW, and I had begun to understand why that mattered.

Part V. Coming Home

20. Pardoned

January 20

On January 20, 2025, President Donald Trump signed the January 6 clemency proclamation. I was pardoned.

After all the waiting, there was a date that changed what came next. I would be able to go home.

For years, home had been something I thought about from somewhere else. It had been phone calls, letters, memories, and the place I hoped I would be able to return to. I had carried my family through days in D.C., through the transfers, and through Beaumont. I had wanted to get back to them.

When I got out and came home, I felt on top of the world.

My Own Bed

The first morning I woke up at home, I was confused for a moment. I was in my bed, and I wondered whether everything had really happened.

It felt as though I had woken up before the trip to Washington. January 4 or January 5, before I left. For a split second, the bed belonged to that earlier life, and I was trying to understand where the years had gone.

Had it all been real?

I had spent so much time wanting to be home that being there did not immediately settle the question. I woke up in a familiar place with memories that did not fit the feeling of that first moment. There was my bed. There had also been the cells, the transfers, and the room at Beaumont. Both were part of my life.

For the first week, I kept waking up with that same sense of disbelief. I could go to sleep at home and then wake up needing a moment to take it in again.

I could not believe it had happened. I could not believe I was back.

Outside Again

Then we would go out, and the world would remind me that it had happened. The years had not been a dream. I had been gone, and now I was here.

I had been released into a life I wanted badly. That mattered. My joy was real. So was the difficulty of understanding, even in my own bed, how I had arrived there after everything that came before it.

I thought I was ready to take on the world. I wanted to return to my family and the life I remembered. I had spent so long looking toward that return that I expected the next part of my life to begin with the same force as the relief I felt.

I was home. Now I had to learn what being home would ask of me.

21. The First Thirty Days

Familiar Things Looked Different

When I came home, everything seemed the same and different at once.

I remember the colors. In prison, I had spent day after day looking at the same walls, sheets, and clothes. There could be color on a television, but that was a small piece of the world in front of me. Coming home meant being surrounded by things I had stopped seeing every day.

I had not forgotten that other colors existed. It was the amount of them, the difference between knowing something was out there and living in it again. Familiar places could look different because I was returning to them from a life that had become narrow and repetitive.

I was happy to be home. I also did not feel as though my mind had simply returned to where it had been before I left. I had been through years that the walls at home could not explain. The familiar things were there, and so was everything I had carried back with me.

I wanted to believe I could recognize my old life and step into it. I had been imagining that return for a long time. Being able to see the place again was only the beginning.

Back to Work

I tried to jump straight back in. I wanted to work and continue the life I had been living before. I had built a business. I was a husband and a father. Those were things I knew how to do, or thought I knew how to do. I wanted to get back to them immediately.

I had promised that I would come home and take care of my family. I meant it when I made that promise. I still meant it when I got home. I wanted to be useful again and take some of the weight that had been carried while I was gone.

But wanting to return to work was not the same as being ready for everything that went with it. My concentration was poor. My thoughts bounced around. I remember noticing it as we talked about the business and tried to get going again. We were also trying to get me help with my mental health.

I was coming out of a place where I had spent so much energy watching people and trying to read what might happen next. I had also been using drugs in prison. I was trying to come home from all of that at the same time I was trying to resume responsibility for a life outside it.

Looking back, I can see how much I was asking of myself. At the time, I saw things that needed doing and wanted to get to them. I knew how to work. Work had been a large part of who I was. Returning to it seemed like the way to return to myself.

The Advice I Did Not Take

My wife told me to stop and take some time for myself.

I should have listened.

She did tell me to slow down. I heard her, and I still tried to move straight into the life I thought I could pick back up.

There were competing things in my head. I knew my family had been tired. I wanted to take care of them. I had been away, and I did not want to spend more time feeling unable to do my part. Yet I was not in the condition I thought I was in. My determination to get moving could not settle every part of what was happening inside me.

That first stretch at home held both things: the relief of being there and the pressure I put on myself to be ready. I could wake up grateful and still have trouble concentrating. I could want to work and still need time. I could love my family and still be struggling with what I had brought back into the house.

I did not understand all of that when I first came home. I was trying to continue. It would take longer for me to recognize how much of prison had continued with me.

22. What Followed Me Home

Two Knocks on the Table

I came home, and eating could still feel dangerous.

I could be going to a meal and find myself thinking somebody might try to stab me. I was no longer on the yard at Beaumont, but I was still carrying the expectation that something could happen while I was trying to eat.

I had spent so much time watching for danger that leaving prison did not immediately change what I expected from people around me. I wanted ordinary life. I also kept bringing the life I had just left into ordinary things.

I felt as though I had to knock twice on the table when I got up.

It was a small action. That made it no less embarrassing when I recognized it outside prison. I had come home wanting to be a husband, a father, and a man who could get back to work. Then a habit from confinement would show up while I was getting up from a table.

I talked to myself too. I had grown used to doing that in solitary. Outside, people could see me doing it, and I would be embarrassed again.

I could know where I was and still find myself doing something I had become used to somewhere else. I could know I was home and still carry fear to a meal. The release had happened. These parts of me had not changed at the same speed.

I did not need a big confrontation for prison to come back into my day. Sometimes it came back in what I expected another

person to do. Sometimes it came back in my own voice, or two knocks against a table.

Burned Popcorn

Later, somebody burned popcorn. I smelled it and ran out.

I had not smelled burned popcorn since prison. There was the smell, and suddenly there was that connection to a place I had left. Even talking about it afterward brought me close to crying.

That surprised me. Popcorn. Something so ordinary that saying the word almost failed to explain what I was trying to tell my dad. How could a smell do that to me?

I could talk about a knife and understand why remembering it hurt. I could describe a lockdown and know why I had not wanted to be there. The popcorn caught me in a different way because it did not look like those memories. I smelled it, and I was out of the room before I had an explanation that felt big enough for my reaction.

I was learning that I did not get to choose every moment when the past would come close. It could happen in the middle of a day that had not been about prison at all.

A Smaller Place

I noticed other habits when I was around people. I would stand up, sit down, and stand up again. I connected that restlessness with all the time I had spent in a cell. Being told to get comfortable did not mean I knew how to settle.

At another point after coming home, I lived in a camper near my parents. My life had become much smaller than the one I had expected to return to. The camper gave me a place to sleep, a bathroom, and a place to work on my computer.

That was what I wanted from it. I did not feel that I needed a whole house around me. I needed to bring things down to an amount I could manage. I have described it as needing to compact my mind. I meant that personally: fewer things around me, the things I needed close enough to use, a place where I could sleep and work.

I am grateful for the time I spent with my parents. I had been used to working so much that I could miss time with them. When I needed somewhere to go, being close to them became part of my life in a way it had not been before.

I did not look at that smaller space and see only what was missing. It was doing what I needed it to do. I could be there. I could use the computer. I could spend time with my mom and dad.

The Truck

During the period when I tried to run for Congress, my dad spent days riding with me in the truck. I thought he was helping as my campaign manager. Looking back, I was mentally unwell, and I believe he could see how serious it was before I could admit it.

I remember him stepping away from preaching to be with me. I knew how much that church meant to him. At the time, though, I understood his presence through what I was trying to do. We were driving around, and Dad was there helping me.

After I had dropped out and was back in the camper, we talked about it. As I remember his words, he told me he had not been acting as my campaign manager. He had been being my daddy, trying to make sure I did not die.

I was thirty-five years old, and I needed my dad.

There had been times when I did not want to keep living. I was struggling with the loss of the family life I had expected, and I could not see clearly beyond it. My father's presence helped me

understand something I had not been able to hold on to: needing a parent does not end when you become an adult.

I needed him at thirty-five. My children could need me when they were grown too.

That thought interrupted the way I had been thinking about my life. I had been looking at what I could not have in that moment. Then I could see years ahead in which being alive and being their dad could still matter.

My dad had stayed close to me. I needed to stay here too.

The Sunset I Kept

There were memories I could return to that did not frighten me.

One was the sunset on the loop in Longview, Texas. When I lay in solitary and needed to think about something good, I would think about that sun going down. I could picture a place I knew and loved. I could go back to it in my mind when what was around me became too much.

It still matters to me. There is something about the evening sky there that does not get old. I can look at it and remember why I kept that picture with me.

The sky looks different to me in different parts of East Texas. Caddo Lake has its own sky in my mind. So do the towns where I have lived. I associate those views with the parts of my life I spent beneath them. Some places remind me of a beginning. Some remind me of what I miss.

The Longview sunset was a memory I carried into confinement. I also carried it out. Not everything that stayed with me came from a cell.

I was still trying to get well. I was still recognizing habits, fears, and ways of thinking that I did not want to keep. But I had my

parents. I had the thought of being there for my children as they grew. I had a place to sleep and a computer where I could work.

I began trying to build something I could be proud of again. I could not do all of it at once. I could sit down at the computer and begin.

Part VI. Rebuilding

23. Building Again From a Laptop

Getting the Equipment Ready

Before I went outside to make the commercial, I put the phone on the stand. I had the microphone on me and the phone microphone ready. I wanted to finish that part before I was standing out in the heat trying to put everything together.

It was a small preparation, but I was learning new methods, new ways. Something had to hold the phone. The sound had to work. I had to get outside and say what I was trying to say.

Then I noticed the car was still running.

I caught myself before leaving it that way. After that came the sound checks. Test, test. More than once. I noticed a truck loaded with tires while I was getting ready. One thing after another caught my attention while I was trying to begin.

I had equipment to manage and words to get through. I was talking, correcting myself, and trying again. Getting back to business included all of that.

This was August 31, 2026. I had spent time talking about what I had brought home from prison and what I wanted to do with my life. That afternoon, I had something specific to finish: a video for the business I was building.

The preparation did not settle everything else. It gave me a task I could work on that afternoon.

Trying to Get the Opening Right

The commercial was aimed at construction businesses. I was trying to talk about equipment sitting idle while a business still had expenses. That was the point I wanted to get across. Before I got there, I had to find an opening I could actually finish.

I began with a question about owning a construction company. Then I stumbled over what the tractors were doing. I tried again. I stopped to ask myself what day it was. Another attempt began with the day of the week. I started over again.

There was a portable toilet nearby, and I tried working it into the comparison. The idea was that an idle tractor was not earning anything for the owner. I wanted an image a person would remember. It was crude, and I thought it was funny. I kept trying to get the take done.

At one point I saw someone coming and became convinced he was going to honk while I was recording. I talked about it as if I could feel it coming. He did not honk. I was still rolling.

Every false start meant finding my place and beginning again. I wanted to finish the commercial, and I kept working at it.

I eventually got through a longer take. I talked about idle equipment, employees who still needed to be paid, materials waiting to be used, and the need for customers. I was raising my voice over the passing eighteen-wheelers. I folded the traffic into what I was saying, and I kept going.

When I finished, I thought the commercial was funny. I repeated the joke to myself. A few minutes later I said I had done the commercial and was ready to head toward the house.

I had got through a take. I had made something I thought could be useful for the business. It had taken several attempts, and I had kept going.

The Pressure to Earn

Almost immediately, I was talking about money again.

I said it was the thirty-first and that I needed checks. I needed work to turn into income. I talked about getting the video out, putting it on the business page and my personal page. Then I made more attempts at the pitch.

That is how unfinished the process still was. I could call a take done and then return to it. Next I wanted to post it, reach customers, and turn the work into income. There were still things to do after getting through the words.

I needed to earn. I wanted the work to lead somewhere. That afternoon, I had made the attempt and completed a take. I was already thinking about what needed to happen next.

Before prison, business had been a large part of my ordinary life. Coming back to work meant doing ordinary tasks again, including the ones that looked awkward while I was doing them. There was no reason every part of rebuilding should arrive as a large public event. Sometimes it was sound equipment, traffic, an opening sentence, and another try.

I was trying to make something with the tools I had and turn it into a living. Finishing the video gave me one piece of that work. I still needed customers.

A Different Night

A few days later, I recorded another account while driving home after work in East Texas. It was after midnight. I kept saying the time as I talked: twelve-thirty, then twelve-thirty-four. I was tired and still some distance from home.

I said I had just finished another job. It had taken hours. I described helping a client with things that needed doing and

putting a website together. I was looking forward to showing what I had been working on.

It was a different night from the afternoon with the commercial. Both were part of the work I was doing around that time: making material for my business and doing a job for a client.

On the drive, I kept moving from the job to what working meant to me. I described having been in a dark place earlier and still struggling. I compared what I was doing that night with the way I remembered spending time before I had begun turning my attention back toward work and family.

The change was not complete. I said that too. I could see a difference and still describe difficulty every day. A late night of work did not supply a finished answer about the rest of my life.

I was speaking forcefully, sometimes as if I were giving advice to whoever might watch. I was also talking to myself about the direction I wanted to keep taking. I wanted to work, provide, and make something of the time I had.

On the Way Home

I stopped for food at a drive-through, ordered, and thanked the person at the window. Then I went back to talking about the job and what I wanted to do next.

I also said that I liked being at home where I felt safe. Even while making a determined speech about moving forward, that feeling remained close to the surface. I could be out doing work and still prefer the security I associated with being home.

I had completed a task that night. I was tired and wanted to get home. I was also still working out how to live with what had followed me there. Doing a job had not made the fear disappear.

Toward the end, I said I was going to get some sleep and get back to work. I was tired, and I wanted to continue after resting.

There is enough in that intention to matter to me. I had something I wanted to return to after I rested. I was looking beyond the hours I had already spent on the job to another piece of work I could do.

The commercial had taken several tries. The client work had taken hours. Those were things I could point to when I said I was trying to rebuild.

I had got through a take. I had finished a job. I was headed home to sleep, with more work ahead.

24. The Record I Kept

Before There Were Chapters

On a drive in August 2026, I said I was going to finish the book on the way over and on the way back. Then, while I was talking about finishing it, I began explaining when I thought it had really started.

I said I had started writing it in the D.C. jail, when I started my grievances.

That was how I understood the connection. The forms did not look like a book. They were requests and complaints, answers and appeals. I was trying to get something addressed while I was still inside. Later, when I tried to explain those years, I had pages made during the years themselves.

They gave me a place to begin that was different from memory alone.

The first page of this book came from one of those forms. There was a request for mental-health help, the institution's answer identifying appointments, and my later disagreement about whether the appointments answered the need. That sequence remained readable after the days themselves had passed.

When I made the recording in August, I connected that kind of record with the book I was now trying to finish. The telling had changed form. I was outside, speaking into a recorder, looking back at what I had written from inside.

I could talk much longer than the space on an inmate form allowed. That did not make the longer version more accurate simply because it contained more words. The page still had a date and the words I had used at the time. It could bring me back to what I had actually asked.

The Other Side of the Form

Keeping the record also meant keeping an answer I did not think was enough.

Some answers did not settle the problem I had raised. I disagreed with them and sometimes appealed. But if a form had a response, I could not call it unanswered. I had to keep the reply and explain what was still wrong.

The mental-health trail makes that distinction visible. It shows me asking for help. It shows the institution saying I had been seen. It shows me explaining why I believed more was needed. Those are different statements made by different people at different points in the process.

There it was on the paper: my request, their answer, my explanation of why I still needed help. I could show the disagreement in the words used at the time.

The March 9 discovery form does something similar. It records that I had access to some discovery through APDS while asking for another kind of access. That is more precise than saying I had no access to anything. The actual request tells the reader what problem I was trying to solve.

The paperwork from 2024 shows another distinction I was trying to make. On March 27, I wrote that officers had asked me to sign a grievance as resolved even though I said I had not been taken to the medical appointment at issue. The next day, I put the distinction in writing again: refusing to sign that the problem was resolved was not the same as refusing medical treatment.

Those pages came back with answers too. The March 27 complaint was returned for containing multiple issues. The March 28 submission was returned as a statement, with instructions to submit my concerns again. Those were procedural answers. They did not decide whether I had been taken to the appointment or whether I had refused care.

The difference is important to me because these pages are part of my own account. They can support a statement. They can also require me to narrow it. Keeping them means making room for both.

I do not lose the experience by describing it carefully. I give someone else a way to follow it.

Talking It Out

Not everything I wanted to describe had a form behind it. Some parts were memories I had to speak through later.

In the recording about solitary confinement, I talked about studying, reading, and keeping paperwork. I also reached a point where I said I did not feel like talking about solitary anymore that night. I said that when more stories came to me, I would put them into the voice recorder.

That is one of the things the recordings preserve: the stopping as well as the telling. I did not always arrive with a complete chapter in order. I could speak about a memory, move to something it reminded me of, and then decide I had said enough for the moment.

The process continued in later recordings. Some were made while I was driving. Others were made while I was working or near the water. A memory could turn up during an ordinary part of the day. Sometimes I was deliberately answering questions to complete the book. Sometimes I was trying to explain something to myself while the recorder was on.

Those recordings gave me more than finished sentences. They held false starts, corrections, and places where I changed the way I described something. They also held ordinary conversation and other people's words. Putting the book together meant finding the part that was actually my account and keeping it connected to the moment when I gave it.

Sometimes I spoke with certainty and had a date wrong. Sometimes I corrected myself later. Sometimes I was describing what I believed another person meant. Going back through my words meant facing those differences as well as remembering what happened.

What I Can Hand Over

The book brings those two kinds of material together: the papers I preserved and the memories I have been able to describe.

Neither one contains every hour. A grievance form is shaped around a complaint and a requested response. It will not necessarily tell someone what I remembered while I lay in a cell, or what it felt like to return to a familiar part of life and find it difficult. A recording can describe those things, but it does not become an independent record of every person, date, or cause mentioned in the telling.

I want someone reading this to be able to find the page behind a claim. I want them to know when I am relying on memory. And I want them to see an answer that differs from mine, even when I still believe that answer failed me.

That is the kind of account I am trying to leave behind. It comes from wanting somebody outside to understand what I was asking for, and from later trying to understand the years as part of a whole life.

Keeping the paperwork was the beginning of the book. Now I can put the words beside the pages. There are memories I have not yet found a way to tell and dates I cannot settle. I can leave those limits visible.

What I can hand over is a story with a record close to it. A reader can move through the life, then return to the source of a particular part and see why I have described it that way.

The man who began those grievances was trying to be heard while he was still inside. The man speaking into the recorder after coming home was trying to explain what had followed him out. This book is one place where those two accounts can meet.

25. Public Identity and Its Cost

Why I Ran

After prison, I put myself back in front of the public. I announced that I wanted to run for Congress.

Looking back, there were several things inside that decision. I wanted to help the country move forward. I was willing to face the scrutiny that came with being a public person again. And I wanted to know whether I was still willing to offer myself for service after everything that had happened. That last question was personal. I had bitterness about serving again, and I did not want to leave the question unanswered.

I wanted to try again. I wanted to be able to look at myself and know that bitterness had not made every decision for me. I had thought much less about whether I was ready for the effort I was choosing.

I knew that putting my name out there meant people would judge me. I was already publicly associated with January 6. Announcing a campaign brought that identity into another setting. It meant asking people to consider me in a new role while they already had opinions about the old one. I understood that much. I cannot look back and say the possibility of public scrutiny surprised me.

What I did not understand was how much difficulty I had brought home with me. I wanted to do the hard thing before I had understood my own condition. I thought I needed to get back out there immediately. I could recognize bitterness. I had much less understanding of why ordinary parts of life were becoming difficult.

I was trying to answer a question about myself by making a very public commitment. That attempt matters to me, even now that I can see how much I did not understand. I was willing to stand in front of people again. I was also a man who had come home carrying more than he knew how to handle.

I have called that attempt a failure. I mean that personally. I set out to do something and did not carry it through the way I had hoped. The campaign had announcements, a withdrawal, another public statement, and later filings. Saying I failed is how I describe my disappointment. It is not the same as saying voters defeated me in an election.

That willingness to try is part of what I remember now.

I can say why I wanted to try. I can also acknowledge that wanting to serve again and understanding what I could manage were two different parts of coming home. At the beginning, I had not worked out how far apart those parts were. The campaign made that gap part of my public life.

Back in Public

The public attempt began in April, less than three months after the pardon. It was a much shorter distance from prison than it can seem when I put the years into a few sentences.

On April 9, 2025, KLTV reported that I had announced a run for Congress. The office was the U.S. House seat for Texas's First District. Two days later, on April 11, KLTV reported a Facebook announcement that I was withdrawing from candidacy. KXII carried that report as well. I had put the idea before the public and then publicly stepped away from it in the space of two days.

There was public activity after that withdrawal. At an April 22 town hall in Tyler, I again said that I planned to challenge the incumbent. KLTV's report the next morning recorded that statement and noted that I had previously dropped out. I had

said I was withdrawing, and then I was standing in public saying I still intended to challenge him.

The federal filings came afterward. A Statement of Candidacy was filed on June 4, 2025, under my FEC candidate record for the 2026 election. The associated principal campaign committee has a June 4 registration date. The FEC also identifies a June 29 Statement of Organization as the current version of that filing.

The April withdrawal was real, and so was the later activity. I cannot make that sequence cleaner by leaving out the part that complicates it. Announcing an intention, stepping away, speaking again, and filing paperwork were different steps. They do not add up to an election result.

I remember eventually being done with the attempt. The June records do not fix that final date, and I cannot place every private conversation on the public calendar. My dad was close to me during that period. The help he gave me, and what I later understood about it, belonged to a life more complicated than campaign announcements could show.

When I look back, I remember the effort and the disappointment. I had wanted to serve again. I had stepped into public view, pulled back, and returned to the idea. It had become part of a difficult homecoming, long before I understood how difficult that homecoming was.

The paperwork could record that I intended to run. It could not tell me whether I was ready.

I had come home and wanted to move forward immediately. The public steps show how quickly I tried to do it. What they do not show is the ordinary day around an announcement, the difficulty of concentrating, or how much help I needed from people close to me. Those things were happening in the same life.

What I Had Not Recognized

The public dates were easier to put in order than what was happening inside my ordinary life.

When I looked back at the campaign period, I could say that I had been mentally unwell. I could name habits I connected with having been in a cell: standing up, sitting down, and standing up again, unable to settle. I could describe them afterward. At the start, I was still telling myself that I needed to get back out in public.

I could not do things the way I remembered doing them before. I said my brain was not functioning at the same rate because that was how thinking and concentrating felt to me. My thoughts bounced around when we tried to talk about the business. I wanted to take responsibility for ordinary work, but wanting to do it did not keep my attention where I needed it.

Some of the clearest examples were smaller than a campaign. They happened around eating and talking and being with people. I could go to a meal at home and still expect that somebody might try to stab me. I was carrying that fear into an ordinary setting. The people around me could be going about their day while I was thinking about danger.

I remembered knocking twice on a table when I got up. I remembered talking to myself, something I associated with being alone in confinement. Around other people afterward, I found it embarrassing. These were things I could describe doing. They helped me explain what I meant by having come home without feeling entirely out of the place I had left.

Before prison, the life I remembered was busy with business, family, and helping people. In a recording, I talked about thinking of that life while I was confined: running a business, being a father, going fishing, taking trips, being involved in the community. I had spent time thinking about ordinary freedom.

Having it available again did not mean that using it felt ordinary right away.

I call it survival mode. I have compared it to a warrior on a battlefield because that was the image that came to mind when I tried to explain how I felt. I had wanted to come back to family life, happy life, ordinary life. Instead, I could be home and still be preparing myself for danger. That is my description of the experience.

I connect those difficulties with prolonged confinement and the violence I remember witnessing. I have described seeing people stabbed and being close enough to remember the smell of blood. I also had mental-health difficulties before January 6. I cannot explain everything that happened to me with one cause. What I can describe is how different ordinary life felt after the places I had been.

When I first came home, I did not understand the extent of these difficulties. Later, I could name more of them. I wish I had understood sooner. At the beginning, though, I was looking at everything I wanted to do and believing I should be able to get back to it.

There were things I wanted to take on and ordinary things I found hard. Both were true in the account I gave. The size of the thing I wanted to do did not tell me how I would manage being around people, eating a meal, or the responsibilities waiting at home.

My father stayed close during the attempt. I have already described what I later came to understand about his presence. At the time, I saw the campaign in front of me. I could announce an intention to return to public life before I understood what returning to daily life was going to require.

I had thought about freedom while confined, and afterward I was still learning what being outside felt like again.

I had wanted ordinary life while I was locked up. Afterward, I could want it just as much and still find myself struggling when I had the chance to be part of it again. Looking back, I see that in the small habits I described, in how I felt around people, and in the fear that could follow me to a meal. Those were part of coming home too.

The Encounters Close to Home

Part of running for office was asking people close to home to support me. I approached local government officials and party organizations in the surrounding cities and counties. I was trying to gather support for the campaign. As I remember it, I could not get the support I was looking for.

That was eye-opening. I had spent so much time thinking about Washington and everything that had happened there.

Washington seemed far away. These were places close to where I lived. Looking back, I found the local part of the effort just as difficult, and at times more difficult, than what I associated with Washington. That is how it felt to me.

I had come home and offered to serve again. That mattered because I had been bitter about serving. Running was one way of finding out whether I was still willing to put myself out there after prison. I knew there would be scrutiny. I wanted to try anyway. I wanted to help the country move forward, and I wanted to prove something to myself about my willingness to do a hard thing.

Seeking support close to home became part of that attempt. So did the disappointment I felt afterward. I had tried to return to public life while I was still struggling with what I had brought home from confinement. I did not understand all of that struggle at the time. Now, when I look back at the campaign, I see both the man who wanted to serve and the man who was having trouble finding his way through ordinary life.

The local experience added to my disillusionment. I came away questioning how much more of myself I wanted to put into politics. The answer I give now is different from the one I gave when I announced that I wanted to run. I no longer want to be a political leader. I do not have that desire anymore.

It has been the whole stretch of my life around January 6: the time before it, the day itself, confinement, and coming home. In my own experience, all of it has changed how I feel about being involved politically. The disappointment close to home belongs within that larger change. It was another part of coming back that I had to work through.

I came away feeling that local politics had its own closed circles and expectations. That was my impression of the encounters. Not getting support does not prove that somebody was corrupt, and I cannot tell another person's motives from a refusal. What I know is how discouraged I became while seeking a place to serve.

What I want now is closer to home too. I want to be there for my family. I want to make money and earn a living. I want to help the community where I can help, and pitch in where I can pitch in. Those are the priorities I come back to when I think about where my effort should go. That is where I am now.

Understanding It Later

I am telling this in September 2026, more than a year and a half after the January 20, 2025 pardon. That is a long time to be home and still be discovering what came home with me. In some ways, I feel as though I am only now beginning to calm down.

I can talk about things I could not describe before. There is more I want to tell, and some of it takes time to get into words. Being able to speak about an experience is a change I can notice even while other parts of my life remain difficult.

At times, I feel able to think in ways that had seemed out of reach. I notice moments when I can appreciate what is around me again. On one drive, I looked at the trees, prayed, and enjoyed being on an open road. I wanted to keep driving through that feeling of freedom.

I talked about feeling less known there. I also qualified the thought: the road might not be entirely unfamiliar, and some people might recognize me. What mattered in that account was the feeling of room to breathe. I wanted more of that freedom with my family.

Those moments sit beside the harder ones. Feeling grateful on a drive does not erase the difficulty of being around people or the fear I remembered around a meal. Nor does a difficult day erase the fact that I could notice something good again.

I can notice something good without having to explain away everything hard.

From here, I can see more of what I did not recognize when I announced the campaign. I understand more about the help I needed. I also understand why the life I want now is different from the one I was trying to launch so quickly after prison. I am still learning what I can manage and where I want to spend my effort.

What Matters to Me Now

What matters to me now is my family, earning a living, and helping in the community where I can. Those are the responsibilities I want to put my effort into. They are close enough to touch and demanding enough to keep me working. I do not need another campaign to give them importance.

Family was central to what I had missed while I was confined. It was part of the life I remembered when I thought about being outside again. In the account of the open road, I wanted to share

that freedom with family. That wish is still part of how I describe the life I am trying to have after prison.

Earning a living belongs beside it. Making money. Before prison, I had business responsibilities. Now I am trying to do paid work again and build something I can be proud of. That means finishing tasks, reaching customers, and coming back to the work when it takes longer than I wanted. Ordinary life takes effort of its own.

I still want to help where I can help and pitch in where I can pitch in. I have spent too much of my life caring about people to pretend that desire is gone. But I am trying to understand my limits, too. Being willing to help does not mean I am ready to take on every problem in front of me.

I no longer want to pursue political leadership. Right now, I do not even know whether I will vote again. That is where I am in my own life. Other people have their own decisions to make about politics. I am trying to be honest about what these years have done to my desire to be involved.

The attempt still matters to me. I put myself back in public. I faced scrutiny. Even though I did not carry it through as I had hoped, I offered to serve again. I wanted to know whether I was still willing to do that hard thing, and I tried. I can value the effort while deciding that I do not want to keep pursuing it.

There are parts of coming home that I can discuss now and parts I am still trying to explain. I have not settled everything. I have work to do, people I want to be present for, and habits I am still learning to understand. Those things deserve my attention today.

I have spoken about wanting to travel with family and about building a life again. Those ordinary hopes belong beside the work of understanding.

I wanted to serve again. I tried. I discovered difficulties I had not understood and reconsidered how I wanted to spend my life. For

now, I want to be there for family, earn a living, and help in the community where I can. There is plenty of work waiting for me close to home.

26. Mercy, Justice, and the Next Rescue

Learning Again

I was talking with my dad about fishing. I had gone out thinking I knew what I was doing and discovered that this was a kind of fishing I had not done before. The weight was making it difficult to feel the fish take the bait. I was trying to learn a different way.

That conversation was recorded in September 2026. We talked about larger fish, about the equipment, and about things that needed to be put away. There were ordinary interruptions. The day was hot, and at one point I talked about closing the window and turning on the air conditioning.

The conversation moved to storms and then to whether I would go out and work another one.

I said I was not going.

That statement was part of a larger change I was trying to describe. Rescue work had been important in my life. I remembered feeling a call to go. In this conversation, I said I did not feel that call in the same way anymore. I also said I felt bad about that sometimes, because I still wanted to serve.

Both things were in what I told my father: the wish to be useful and the recognition that I did not want to take on that kind of work again then. I was trying to say something about my own limits, in a conversation that had begun with learning to fish differently.

The Words I Said

My father spoke about something he would have liked to do but could not. I began talking about the service he had already given. Then I applied the same thought to myself.

“You don't owe anything else.”

I said it to him, and I was trying to hear it for myself. He had served. I had served. I wanted to recognize what we had already given without turning the next rescue into something we had to do to prove it.

I was talking about the next rescue, the next effort beyond what we had already done. I still had responsibilities at home. I still wanted to work and rebuild. Those things had not disappeared because I no longer wanted to go into another storm.

I could recognize the good I associated with service and also recognize costs I had not understood in the same way before. That was part of what I said in the conversation. Having meant to do good did not give me a complete understanding of what an effort would require or how I would experience it afterward.

I was trying to acknowledge what we had done and what I did not want to keep asking of myself.

What I Still Carry

The same limit is part of how I talk about anger. I have described what I believe happened to me and what I experienced afterward. I have also recorded moments when I was trying to decide how I wanted to carry that experience into the next part of my life.

On one drive, I prayed and then spoke about still having anger. I did not claim that it had all gone away. I was trying to recognize the part of my own conduct I could take responsibility for without pretending that every harm I had experienced was my own doing.

That distinction matters at the end of this account. I can describe things that hurt me without making them the explanation for every decision I make afterward. I can acknowledge my choices without saying that every part of what happened was deserved. Neither statement needs to swallow the other.

There were people whose actions I remember with gratitude in places that frightened me. An officer let me call home. Charlie helped me make another call. A caseworker kept a move going when I resisted it. I carry those memories alongside the harder ones. I carry my own mistakes, too.

I have not reached a point in the telling where one emotion can explain everything. I can be grateful for an act of help and angry about something else. I can want accountability and still be trying to find a less consuming place for anger in my own days.

I am still working on that. I have not finished with forgiveness or settled every disagreement.

What Help Looks Like Now

Family. Earning a living. Helping in the community where I can. That is the direction I want to keep moving.

Those responsibilities need my attention. I have struggled through work, corrected a take, driven home tired, and planned to sleep before getting back to it. I have spent time learning something alongside my dad. Those are smaller pieces of a life than a rescue story, but they belong in the same life.

I also want to leave these years in a form another person can follow. That is something I hope the book can do: put the story and the record close enough together that someone can understand what I experienced and examine what I kept.

For now, I have work to do close to home. I have family I want to be present for. I have experiences I am still learning to describe.

The next thing that matters does not always arrive as an emergency somewhere else.

I said the words to my dad, and I was trying to hear them for myself: we had served. I could recognize that part of my life and still give attention to the life in front of me.

Epilogue. By the Water

Another Day

I had gone down near the lake thinking I would make a video. I did not know exactly what kind. Then I got emotional, and what I began doing was praying.

In the recording, I tried to tell myself not to cry. I had been avoiding some videos because I became emotional in ways I had not been used to before. I thought people needed to see me composed. Then I looked at the place where I was and began saying thank you.

I thanked God for another day. For being able to see the water and hear the waves. For the sunrise and the clouds. I talked about the rocks and the water level, and I was thankful that the lake was there at all.

I had spent time thinking I would not get to see a view like that again for a long while. Now I was standing beside it.

I had known I wanted to make some kind of video. I had not known it would involve crying or talking to God.

The View in Front of Me

While I was in confinement, I had remembered sunsets. I thought about the ones I knew from East Texas. I could return to the view in my mind when I wanted something positive to think about.

That morning by the lake, I was outside. Water, sky, trees, air. I was thankful for having a phone and being able to stand there and speak.

I also talked about the dark places I had been in. Gratitude did not make me unable to remember them. The two parts were in the same recording. I could say I was hurt and still be grateful for the place where I had begun the day.

I had thought of becoming emotional as weakness. In that morning's account, I tried to describe it differently. I said that I was hurt. I said it still hurt. I was trying to understand my own response without making it the only thing I could see about myself.

I was home. I could look at the water, and I was thankful to be there.

Thank You

Toward the end, a bird caught my attention. I tried to identify it, changed my mind, and looked again. The species is not what stays with me about that part of the recording. I had stopped explaining myself long enough to notice something in the sky.

I said how beautiful it was. Then I thanked God again.

I did not expect the video to turn out that way. I had planned to make something. Then came the view, the emotion, the prayer, the interruption of a bird.

There was another day. There was water I could see and air I could breathe. I was able to stand there and say what I was thankful for.

Thank you, Lord.

Source Notes

The principal sources are Ryan Nichols's recorded accounts, contemporaneous handwritten material, correspondence, grievances, and court records. Private recordings and supporting papers are retained in the author's archive. These notes distinguish those sources from institutional responses and public filings. They do not represent a claim that every file in the larger archive has been reviewed.

The source references below follow the chapter order. Dates attached to recorded accounts identify the telling, not necessarily the event. Court filings are described according to their role in the case. Relief requested, relief granted, and a case ending without a decision on the merits are different events.

Prologue. Grievance Resolved

The reproduced complaint was signed March 24, 2022. It appears on page 86 of the author's 200-page GRIEVANCES.pdf collection. The institutional response is dated April 1 and records appointments on March 25 and March 30. The April 13 formal complaint, page 100, disputes the adequacy of those contacts. The account of beginning the book by keeping grievances comes from the author's August 31, 2026 recording.

1. East Texas

The author's August 29, 2026 account supplies the bus bedroom, family moves, the encounter at the door, and the people who helped him. Childhood ages are approximate recollections. The chapter does not assign an unverified motive to the person at the door. Mary Crippen's April 11, 2024 handwritten letter, criminal ECF303-9, page 43, supplies her classroom recollection. Her falling-bookshelf account is not fused with a different description in the father's letter.

2. Becoming a Marine

Recorded accounts from April 13 and May 12, 2025, and August 29, 2026, describe joining, training, Okinawa, the call home, and friendship. The DD214 records active service from October 18, 2010, through October 17, 2014, honorable discharge, and the rank of corporal. The service records of another person are not used to establish the author's service.

3. Running Toward the Missing

The rescue and friendship accounts draw on the author's recordings from April 12–13, 2025. Supporting character letters include an April 6, 2021 letter describing rescue work, a January 3, 2020 Cajun Navy letter, and a December 10, 2021 letter from Alex Harkrider. A witness's description remains that witness's account; estimates of assistance are not treated as an independently audited rescue total.

4. Building Something From Nothing

The principal sources are the author's August 31, 2026 business account, an April 13, 2025 recording, and a February 17, 2021 supporting letter. Statements about the operation and the author's intentions are distinct from independently documented revenue or loss. Brittney Browning's undated signed letter, ECF303-9, pages 10–12, describes her work beginning in 2017 and the mask-making and employee assistance she witnessed during the pandemic. No independent payroll or delivery total is claimed.

5. What I Believed, and Why I Went

The author's April and May 2025 recordings describe his beliefs and preparations. His written Timeline Of Events and later spoken account differ on the Virginia arrival date, so the chapter does not assign an exact arrival day. The public case account is also reflected in the Department of Justice sentencing release, May 2, 2024. A belief about the election is presented as the author's belief.

6. The Morning and the Walk

The main sources are the author's April 13, April 30, and May 9, 2025 recordings. The chapter preserves his account of what he carried and used, as well as the limited view from his position in the crowd. It does not claim knowledge of every participant's intentions.

7. The Tunnel and the Cameras

The author described these events in recordings dated May 9 and May 12, 2025, and June 5, 2026. His account is presented alongside the Department of Justice plea release, November 7, 2023, and sentencing release. Public case accounts concerning the attack on Officer Michael Fanone also include the February 14 and June 21, 2023 releases concerning Daniel Rodriguez. The chapter distinguishes what the author remembers doing from claims about other participants and from what a camera could establish. The author's signed statement of offense, ECF280, pages 7–8 and 12–14, is a direct source for his admissions. It places the spraying at approximately 4:02 p.m.; the public summary gives approximately 4:01. Both are approximate, and the difference is retained.

8. The Night After

The principal source is the author's June 5, 2026 account, read with his earlier account of January 6 and the November 7, 2023 plea release. His statements about recorded videos and deletion are retained. His account does not establish what another person privately decided or intended.

9. Arrest and Arrival

The author's recorded recollections are read with the January 22, 2021 Tyler detention-hearing transcript, supplied in two files with continuous printed pagination. Relevant passages include pages 62–63, 90–104, 110–111, and 120–121. They cover the GoPro-production correction, Bonnie's testimony, the statement read by counsel, the Pretrial Services recommendation, and the detention ruling. A detention decision is distinct from a verdict of guilt.

10. The D.C. Jail

The central sources are the author's recorded arrival account and August 26, 2026 description of jail routines. The chapter keeps remembered routines tied to the periods he describes; a routine at one time is not presented as the unchanging schedule for the entire detention.

11. Alone

The author's recorded accounts of confinement, including September 5, 2026 recollections, supply the experience of isolation. The requests for care and the institutional replies are developed more fully in Chapter 13. Descriptions of the author's distress are not converted into an unsupported diagnosis or a claim of permanent injury.

12. The People Who Still Saw Me

The author's recorded accounts supply the voices, songs, calls, and acts of help. Five retained officer evaluations are dated August 12, August 17, August 24, September 1, and November 16, 2021. Franklin's written comments also describe the author's conduct. Favorable evaluations describe their own periods and do not decide every later disputed incident.

13. Grievance Resolved

The principal original pages in GRIEVANCES.pdf are 86, 100, 96, 167, 154, 179–180, 186, 183, 182, 184, and 181. The care sequence includes the March 24 request, the April 1 response, the April 13 formal complaint, and later appeals. The April 20 reply was recorded by Debra Jones on behalf of Bruce Reid. Contemporaneous notes distinguish the May 9 move to NW1B from the May 10 move to C2B. Blank answer spaces are not treated as proof that no other response exists.

14. Taking the Record Outside

The March 9 discovery complaint appears on page 113 of GRIEVANCES.pdf. The habeas petition, Nichols v. Garland, civil case 1:22-cv-02356, ECF 1, was filed August 10, 2022. The civil docket records voluntary dismissal; criminal ECF 177, page 1, note 1, describes counsel's explanation for withdrawal. Criminal ECF 150, 161, 168, 169 and its Washington affidavit, 172, and 177 contain the competing discovery-drive accounts. ECF 172 acknowledges the Rappahannock restriction on electronic review outside attorney visits. The filings do not establish a forensic finding that a drive was copied. Tablets, laptops, drives, and attorney-visit access are kept distinct. The September 12, 2022 transfer date is supported by the saved same-day Gross–Ruffin correspondence (J6 scan series 7, images 026 and 038–043), with the earlier Gross–Glover exchange in series 8, images 008–009. A draft outline giving September 6 conflicts with that dated official correspondence. The October 17 request, October 19 reply, October 26 grievance and October 27 return are series 8 images 047, 045 and 044. The August 26 handwritten account, signed by the author and two prisoners, records a conversation about an asserted Marshals report (series 8 image 090); it is not the report itself.

15. Home, With Conditions

Criminal ECF180 records the conditions of release; ECF197 and 224 provide later procedural context. Wayne Taylor's letter and Rodney LaJoie's April 22, 2024 email, ECF303-9, pages 71 and 61, describe church contact and home visits. Their opinions remain distinct from findings about compliance.

The author's recorded accounts, Leading Up To January 6, 1% WatchDog, and Marcus DiPaola, supply his recollections of rescue contacts, preparations and conversations. Requests concerning alleged government connections appear in ECF244, June 20, 2023, pages 4–8 and 13–14, and ECF245, June 21, pages 6–11. The government's awareness and disclosure position appear in ECF247, July 3, pages 12–13 and note 5; the defense's acknowledgment and dispute appear in ECF251, July 19, page 3. ECF266, October 16, pages 19–20 and 27, denies the discovery motions and rejects the showing made for the alleged-informant requests. These records do not establish government direction of either individual in January 2021.

ECF280, pages 12–14, contains the author's signed admissions, including acting of his own accord. The signatures are dated October 2, 2023, before the October 16 discovery ruling; the plea hearing was November 7 and the statement was filed November 8. The November 7 plea release and ECF314 supply the plea and judgment. The later recollection of feeling manipulated is not substituted for the signed admissions.

The January and March 2024 care-request account comes from ECF303-8, pages 16 and 21–25, a selected exhibit of medical records and grievances filed April 29, 2024. Pages 16 and 21 duplicate one grievance. The exhibit includes treatment entries, institutional responses and disputed refusal/no-show entries. It is not the complete clinical chart and does not establish deliberate misconduct or the cause of each medical condition.

16. Sixty-Three Months

The judgment in criminal ECF 314 supplies the concurrent prison terms, supervised release, and separate financial provisions. The author's recorded recollections describe the experience of sentencing and placement. A judicial placement recommendation is distinguished from where he recalls actually being sent. The full May 2, 2024 sentencing transcript, ECF316, records the competing sentencing requests, the judge's comments on the family videos, the author's allocution, and the reasons given for the sentence and fine. Relevant passages are pages 3–15, 27–52 and 55. The courtroom scene is an editorial adaptation of that transcript. The family videos themselves and the private presentence financial report are not claimed as separately reviewed.

17. Con Air

The chapter draws on the author's recorded accounts of transport, Lewisburg, Oklahoma City, and the southbound trip, including August 29 and September 5, 2026 recollections. In the Lewisburg violence account, the author does not claim to have seen the injured man die or to know his later outcome.

18. The Yard

The source is the author's recorded account of the people and incidents he describes, including September 1, 2, and 5, 2026 conversations. Descriptions of the knife encounter, prison drug use, and missing Suboxone remain firsthand recollections. An accusation about who took an item is not converted into an established fact.

19. People Behind the Doors

The principal sources are the author's September 5, 2026 account and earlier recordings about the move from the medium to the low. The chapter distinguishes assistance he hoped to obtain from the transfer he remembers actually taking place.

20. Pardoned

The presidential proclamation of January 20, 2025, supplies the public pardon action. The author's August 31, 2026 recording supplies the first night in his own bed and the experience of being outside again.

21. The First Thirty Days

The author's August 29, 2026 recollections and related homecoming recording supply the attempts to work, concentration difficulties, and advice to slow down. These are accounts of functioning after release, not medical measurements.

22. What Followed Me Home

The chapter draws on recordings from August 31 and September 2, 4, and 5, 2026. The Truck remains the principal account of the father's presence during the campaign and the author's later understanding of it. Historical distress is described within that remembered period. The sunset passages come from the author's own recorded recollection.

23. Building Again From a Laptop

The sources are the author's August 31 and September 4, 2026 recordings of business work, retakes, financial pressure, and driving home. Intentions to earn and work in progress are not presented as completed sales or independently verified business results.

24. The Record I Kept

The author's August 31, 2026 account links the grievances to the beginning of the book. The original March 9 discovery complaint, the March–April mental-health sequence, and the author's later discussions of those records supply the examples. The chapter preserves both the complaint and the institutional answer. The March 27 and March 28, 2024 grievances distinguish the author's refusal to sign a matter as resolved from his position that he had not refused medical care. The retained April 24 returns identify procedural grounds: multiple issues and a statement requiring resubmission (J6 scan series 9, images 043–045 and 048–050). These forms do not resolve the clinical dispute.

25. Public Identity and Its Cost

The central new source is the author's September 2026 annotation to the chapter plan, supplemented by August 31 and September 5 recordings. The campaign chronology draws on April 9 reporting of the announcement, April 11 reporting of withdrawal, and April 23 town-hall reporting. Later records include the June 4 FEC filing, the committee record, and a June 29 filing. They establish later filing activity, not by themselves an election result or a final withdrawal date. Previously reviewed 2019–2020 medical records establish mental-health history before January 6. Local encounters remain the author's unnamed personal account.

26. Mercy, Justice, and the Next Rescue

The sources are the author's September 1 and September 5, 2026 conversations, the chapter-plan annotation, and the rebuilding accounts. The line about not owing another rescue was spoken by the author in the recorded exchange. The chapter does not claim that forgiveness or recovery is complete.

Epilogue. By the Water

The source is the author's September 3, 2026 lakeside recording, with the remembered-sunset passage from September 4. The prayer, emotion, view, and bird belong to that account. The narrative is an editorial adaptation of the recording, not a newly invented scene.